

THE COMPLETE COURSE GUIDE

FREELANCE WEB DESIGN & DEVELOPMENT

From zero clients to a fully operational freelance business

8

Modules

47

Lessons

12

Templates

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One-time payment · Lifetime access · 30-day money-back guarantee

freelancewebcourse.com

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FREE MODULE

MODULE 1

Mindset & Market Reality

"Understand the game before you play it"

MILESTONE

Written 90-day plan + niche hypothesis

Lessons in this module

- 1.1** Why Freelancing Works — and Why Most Fail
- 1.2** Choosing Your Stack & Specialization
- 1.3** Picking Your Niche — The \$10K/Month Decision
- 1.4** Setting Goals & Building Your 90-Day Plan

MODULE 1

LESSON 1.1

Why Freelancing Works — and Why Most Fail

The 3 income phases · Building a business vs. a hustle

The Honest Truth About Freelancing

Freelance web design and development is one of the most accessible paths to a high income in 2025 — but only for people who treat it like a business from day one. The web is the world's largest marketplace, and every single business on the planet either has a website already or needs one. The demand is enormous and growing. The Bureau of Labor Statistics projects web developer employment to grow 7% between 2024 and 2034 — more than twice the average for all occupations.

Yet the majority of people who try freelancing fail within the first six months. Not because they can't code or design. Because they have no system. They rely on luck, post in random Facebook groups, wait for referrals that never arrive, and burn out wondering why clients aren't finding them. This course fixes that. You will leave with a repeatable, predictable system for getting clients and growing income.

Why Most Freelancers Fail: The Real Reasons

No niche. Generalists compete on price. Specialists command premium fees. 'I do websites' is not a business offer.

No portfolio system. They wait for real clients before building a portfolio. You will build yours first — with or without clients.

No outreach process. They post once on Instagram and wait. Clients don't come to you in year one; you go to them.

Underpricing out of fear. New freelancers charge \$200 for a site that should cost \$1,500 and resent every minute of it.

No contract, no deposit. One bad client with no contract will wipe out months of profit and morale.

Feast-or-famine cycle. They work on a project, ignore marketing; when it ends, they scramble. No pipeline = no business.

The 3 Income Phases Every Freelancer Goes Through

Understanding which phase you're in removes anxiety and sets the right expectations. Most beginners try to skip Phase 1 and go straight to Phase 3. That never works.

Phase	Timeline	Monthly Revenue	Your #1 Focus
Phase 1: Survival	Months 1–3	\$0 – \$2,000	First 2–3 clients, proof of concept
Phase 2: Stability	Months 4–9	\$2,000 – \$6,000	Repeatable pipeline, retainers
Phase 3: Scale	Month 10+	\$6,000 – \$15,000+	Systems, team, passive income

KEY INSIGHT: Building a Business vs. a Hustle

A hustle trades time for money and stops when you stop. A business has systems, a pipeline, packages, and repeatable processes that work while you sleep. Every decision you make from day one should be building toward the business, not the hustle. This means: creating templates, writing processes down, raising rates intentionally, and never relying on a single client for more than 40% of revenue.

What the First 90 Days Actually Look Like

Week 1–2: Set up your mindset, choose your niche, pick your tools. Week 3–4: Build two spec sites and publish your portfolio. Week 5–6: Begin warm outreach — message 50 people in your network. Week 7–8: Apply to five freelance platform projects. First paid project. Week 9–10: Deliver excellently, request testimonial, ask for referral. Week 11–12: Follow up on all warm leads, begin cold outreach to local businesses. By the end of month 3, you should have 1–2 paid projects completed and a working pipeline.

Common Mindset Trap: Waiting Until You're Ready

There is no 'ready.' Every successful freelancer launched before they felt confident. The first client teaches you more than 100 hours of tutorials. Your job in week one is not perfection — it is momentum. Progress beats perfection every single time.

ACTION TASK — Before You Move On

Write down in a notebook or Google Doc:

1. Why do you want to freelance? (Be honest — freedom, income, escape a job?)
2. What is your current monthly income goal for month 3?
3. What is your biggest fear about starting? Name it out loud.

Naming your fears removes their power. Keep this document — you'll look back at it.

MODULE 1

LESSON 1.2

Choosing Your Stack & Specialization

Frontend · Full-stack · No-code — what the market actually pays for

Stack Choices: The Decision That Shapes Everything

The tool you choose to build websites is not just a technical decision — it determines your client type, your income ceiling, your learning curve, and how fast you can deliver projects. In 2025, three paths dominate the freelance web market.

Path 1: No-Code / Visual Builders

Tools: WordPress + Elementor/Divi, Webflow, Framer, Squarespace, Wix. No-code is the fastest path to your first dollar. You can build a professional 5-page business website in a weekend without writing a single line of code. The market for no-code sites is enormous — the vast majority of small businesses don't need custom code; they need a good-looking, functional site.

Income range: \$800 – \$8,000 per project. **Best for:** Beginners who want clients fast. **Ceiling:** High — Webflow specialists regularly charge \$5,000–\$15,000 for complex builds.

Path 2: Frontend Custom Code

Tools: HTML, CSS, JavaScript, React, Tailwind CSS. You build sites from scratch with code. Higher perceived value, more complex projects, higher rates — but a steeper learning curve. Typical timeline to first paid project: 3–6 months of learning before you're client-ready.

Income range: \$2,000 – \$20,000+ per project. **Best for:** Those willing to invest 3–6 months learning before earning. **Ceiling:** Very high.

Path 3: Full-Stack Development

Tools: Node.js, Python/Django, PHP/Laravel, databases, APIs. Full-stack adds backend logic, databases, and server-side work. This is the highest-paying path but requires the most skill. Not recommended for pure beginners — focus on one front end first, add backend later.

Income range: \$5,000 – \$50,000+ per project. **Best for:** Those with existing dev background or willing to invest 12+ months.

Path	Time to First \$	Typical Rate	Best Tool to Learn First
No-code (WordPress)	2–6 weeks	\$800–\$5,000/site	WordPress + Elementor
No-code (Webflow)	4–8 weeks	\$2,000–\$12,000/site	Webflow University (free)
Frontend custom code	3–5 months	\$2,000–\$15,000/site	HTML/CSS JavaScript
Full-stack	6–12 months	\$5,000–\$50,000+	Node.js or Django

Recommended Starter Stack for Beginners (2025)

WordPress + Elementor OR Webflow. Both have massive job markets, excellent free learning resources, and let you deliver professional results fast. WordPress powers 43% of all websites on the internet — the demand is virtually unlimited. Webflow is growing fast with agencies and offers higher rates. Pick one. Learn it deeply. Resist tool-hopping.

The 'Learn vs. Earn' Balance

Many beginners spend 12 months learning before they ever try to get a client. This is a mistake. The correct approach: learn just enough to deliver a basic site (4–6 weeks), then get your first client. You will learn 10x more working on a real project with a real deadline than you ever will from tutorials alone. Tutorials teach syntax. Clients teach business.

ACTION TASK — Stack Decision

Decide your path right now. Write it down:

My chosen stack is: [WordPress / Webflow / Custom Code]

My reason: [speed to income / existing skills / long-term interest]

Time I will commit to learning per week: [X hours]

Date I will have my first demo site built: [DATE]

MODULE 1

LESSON 1.3

Picking Your Niche — The \$10K/Month Decision

High-value niches · Evaluation framework · Specialists earn 2–3x more

Why Niche Selection Is the Highest-ROI Decision You'll Make

If you only take one thing seriously from this entire module, make it this: picking a niche will make or break your freelance business. A freelancer who says 'I build websites for everyone' competes with every other web designer on price. A freelancer who says 'I build websites for dental practices in Texas' competes with almost no one — and can charge accordingly.

Specialists consistently earn 2–3x more than generalists for equivalent work. A dentist is far more likely to hire someone who specifically understands their industry, their patient acquisition challenges, and their compliance needs — even if that specialist charges double.

The 3 Niche Dimensions

A strong niche has up to three dimensions: **Who** (the client type), **What** (the service), and **Where** (geography or platform). You don't need all three, but more specificity = less competition and higher rates.

Vague (avoid)	Good	Excellent
Web designer	Web designer for restaurants	Webflow designer for upscale restaurants in NYC
WordPress developer	WordPress developer for coaches	WordPress + membership sites for online business coaches
Website builder	E-commerce developer	Shopify developer for beauty & cosmetics brands
UI/UX designer	Designer for SaaS startups	Mobile-first UI designer for B2B SaaS products

High-Value Niches in 2025

Healthcare & Medical Practices: \$3,000–\$10,000/site — doctors, dentists, physios all need local SEO sites. High trust = high budget.

Law Firms & Legal Services: \$4,000–\$15,000/site — lawyers understand the value of digital presence and have the budget.

Real Estate Agents & Brokerages: \$2,000–\$8,000/site — highly competitive space, agents spend freely on marketing.

Restaurants & Food Businesses: \$1,500–\$5,000/site — huge volume, repeat maintenance revenue from menu updates.

E-commerce (Shopify/WooCommerce): \$5,000–\$25,000/store — the most lucrative single project type.

SaaS & Tech Startups: \$8,000–\$40,000/project — high budgets, complex needs, repeat work.

Coaches & Course Creators: \$2,000–\$8,000/site — exploding market, need memberships and funnels.

Local Service Businesses: \$1,200–\$4,000/site — plumbers, electricians, landscapers — volume play.

The Niche Evaluation Framework

Score each potential niche on these 5 criteria (1–5 each). Highest score wins.

Criterion	What to Ask	Score /5
Market size	Are there thousands of potential clients?	
Willingness to pay	Do they spend money on marketing?	
Your interest/knowledge	Do you already know this industry?	
Competition level	Are there few niche specialists?	
Recurring revenue potential	Do they need ongoing maintenance?	

Niche Paralysis Is Real — Here's How to Beat It

You don't need to commit to a niche forever. Pick the best hypothesis right now and test it for 60 days. If you get interest, go deeper. If not, pivot. Your niche evolves with your portfolio and your clients. Action beats analysis every time.

ACTION TASK — Write Your Niche Statement

Write your niche hypothesis:

I help [TYPE OF BUSINESS] get [SPECIFIC RESULT] through [YOUR SERVICE].

Example: 'I help independent restaurants in [City] attract more customers through professionally designed, mobile-first websites and Google Business optimization.'

MODULE 1

LESSON 1.4

Setting Goals & Building Your 90-Day Plan

Realistic revenue targets · The part-time to full-time roadmap

The Document That Separates Dreamers from Earners

A 90-day plan is a specific, written, week-by-week action plan. It replaces vague ambitions ('I want more clients') with concrete targets ('I will send 10 outreach messages per day Monday–Friday, targeting restaurant owners in my city'). People with written plans are 42% more likely to achieve their goals — and in freelancing, the gap between having a plan and not having one is the difference between \$0 and \$3,000 in month three.

Setting Realistic Revenue Targets

Timeline	Realistic Monthly Revenue	How to Get There
Month 1	\$0 – \$800	1 small project or 1 free project for testimonial
Month 2	\$500 – \$2,000	1–2 paid projects, word-of-mouth starting
Month 3	\$1,500 – \$4,000	2–3 projects, first retainer client
Month 6	\$3,000 – \$7,000	Steady pipeline, raised rates, repeat clients
Month 12	\$5,000 – \$15,000+	Referral engine, retainers, possibly outsourcing

Your 90-Day Weekly Action Plan Template

Week 1–2: Choose niche. Choose stack. Set up Figma and your build tool. Study 1–2 examples of excellent sites in your niche.

Week 3–4: Build Spec Site #1 — a fake business in your niche. Publish it live. Create a simple portfolio page (even one page is enough).

Week 5–6: Build Spec Site #2. Write your first case study. Create your outreach message template. Message 20 people in your network.

Week 7–8: Apply to 5 freelance platform projects (Upwork or Contra). Send 5 cold emails to local businesses with bad websites. First discovery call if possible.

Week 9–10: Deliver your first project (paid or pro-bono). Request a testimonial. Add the project to your portfolio. Ask for one referral.

Week 11–12: Follow up on all warm leads. Begin posting once a week on LinkedIn. Research agency partnership opportunities. Plan month 4.

Part-Time to Full-Time Roadmap

Most people starting freelance are doing it alongside a job. That's smart — never quit your job until your freelance income has replaced at least 80% of your salary for three consecutive months. Here's the typical transition path:

Months 1–3: Side income (\$0–\$2K/mo). Nights and weekends. Build portfolio, land first clients.

Months 4–6: Part-time serious (\$2K–\$5K/mo). Consider reducing hours at job. Strong pipeline forming.

Months 7–9: Transition zone (\$4K–\$8K/mo). When 3 months consistent income = your salary, plan the exit.

Month 10+: Full-time freelance. Full focus, higher rates, scaling begins.

Module 1 Complete — Key Takeaways

Most freelancers fail from lack of system, not lack of skill.

Pick your stack (WordPress or Webflow recommended) and commit for 90 days.

Niche down immediately — specialists earn 2–3x generalists.

Write your 90-day plan this week. Then execute it one week at a time.

MODULE 1 MILESTONE — 90-Day Plan

Write your full 90-day plan. Include:

- Your income goal for months 1, 3, 6, and 12
- Your chosen niche and stack
- Week-by-week tasks for the next 12 weeks (use the template above)
- The date you will have your portfolio live

Keep this document open. Review it every Sunday.

FREE MODULE

MODULE 2

Skills, Tools & Tech Stack

"Get tool-ready — know what to learn, skip the rest"

MILESTONE

Working demo site published live

Lessons in this module

- 2.1** The Minimal Viable Tech Stack
- 2.2** Design Fundamentals for Non-Designers
- 2.3** The Modern Web Designer's Workflow
- 2.4** AI Tools That Will Double Your Speed
- 2.5** Build Your First Demo Site

MODULE 2**LESSON 2.1**

The Minimal Viable Tech Stack

WordPress vs. Webflow vs. custom code — which path to take and when

The Tool Trap: Why Less Is More

One of the biggest mistakes new web designers make is tool-hopping. They spend three months learning WordPress, then switch to Webflow, then see a YouTube video about Framer, then spend a week comparing React frameworks. Meanwhile, someone else landed four clients. The rule is simple: pick one build tool, become excellent at it, earn money. Add tools only when a client's needs genuinely require it.

Your Core Tool Stack

Design — Figma

Free tier is more than enough. Used by virtually every professional design team. Learn the basics in 2–3 days.

Cost: figma.com — free

Code Editor — VS Code

Free, industry-standard editor for all code. Thousands of extensions. Even if you use no-code tools, you'll need this for tweaks.

Cost: code.visualstudio.com — free

CMS / Builder — WordPress + Elementor OR Webflow

WordPress: powers 43% of the web. Elementor makes it visual and fast. Webflow: cleaner code, steeper learning, higher-end clients.

Cost: Both have free plans to start

Local Dev — Local by Flywheel

Test WordPress sites on your own computer before pushing live. No hosting costs during development.

Cost: localwp.com — free

Version Control — GitHub

Save and track every version of your code. Looks professional to developer clients. Free for public repos.

Cost: github.com — free

AI Assist — Claude or GitHub Copilot

Claude for writing, strategy, and code generation. Copilot for inline code completion as you type. Both are transformative for speed.

Cost: [claude.ai](#) / [GitHub Copilot](#)

Project Management — Notion or Trello

Track client projects, deliverables, deadlines. Keep everything out of your head and into a system.

Cost: Free tiers sufficient

Invoicing — Wave or Bonsai

Send professional invoices, accept online payments, track expenses. Wave is free; Bonsai is \$24/mo with more features.

Cost: [waveapps.com](#) — free

Total Cost of Your Starter Stack: \$0–\$50/month

Every tool above has a free tier sufficient to start. You do not need to spend money on tools before you have clients. Once you earn your first \$1,000, invest \$25–\$50/month in a Webflow plan or Bonsai for professional invoicing. Your tools cost should never exceed 5% of your revenue.

WordPress vs. Webflow: The Real Comparison

Factor	WordPress + Elementor	Webflow
Learning curve	Moderate (2–4 weeks)	Moderate-high (4–8 weeks)
Client base	SMBs, local businesses, blogs	Agencies, startups, tech companies
Typical project rate	\$800 – \$5,000	\$2,000 – \$12,000
Hosting	Client manages (SiteGround, WP Engine)	Webflow Hosting (built-in)
Code quality	Variable (plugin-dependent)	Clean semantic HTML/CSS
Job market size	Enormous — most sites are WP	Growing fast, niche premium
Recommended if...	You want clients fast	You want higher rates per project

ACTION TASK — Stack Setup Checklist

This week — set up your entire tool stack:

- [] Create a free Figma account at figma.com
- [] Install VS Code at code.visualstudio.com
- [] Create a free WordPress.com or Webflow.com account
- [] Download Local by Flywheel (for WordPress users)
- [] Create a GitHub account
- [] Sign up for Claude at claude.ai (free tier)
- [] Set up a free Notion account for project management

MODULE 2

LESSON 2.2

Design Fundamentals for Non-Designers

Contrast · Repetition · Alignment · Proximity · Color · Typography

You Don't Need to Be an Artist — You Need to Know the Rules

The most common fear among non-designers entering web design is 'I'm not creative.' Here's the truth: professional web design is 80% following established principles and 20% creative judgement. The principles can be learned in a single week. Once you understand them, you'll look at any website and immediately know what's working, what isn't, and how to fix it.

The 4 Core Design Principles (C.R.A.P.)

Every well-designed website uses these four principles. They were formalized by designer Robin Williams and remain the foundation of all visual communication.

Contrast. Make different things look different. Headlines vs body text. Buttons vs background. Dark vs light. If two elements aren't the same, make them very different — never almost the same. Almost-same is the enemy of good design.

Repetition. Repeat design elements throughout the site. Same font for all H2s. Same button color everywhere. Same card layout for all service items. Repetition creates consistency and professionalism.

Alignment. Nothing is placed randomly. Every element aligns to an invisible grid. Left-aligned text, right-aligned images — both work, but they must be intentional. Misalignment looks amateurish.

Proximity. Related items group together. The heading and its description should be close. Unrelated items have space between them. White space is not empty — it's a design element that guides the eye.

Color Theory Essentials

You don't need to understand the full color wheel. You need three colors per website: a primary (your brand color), a secondary (for accents), and a neutral (for text and backgrounds). Use the 60-30-10 rule: 60% neutral, 30% primary, 10% accent.

Safe starter palettes for business sites: Navy + White + Gold | Dark Green + Cream + Forest | Deep Blue + Light Gray + Orange. Use [Colors.co](#) or [Adobe Color](#) to generate professional palettes instantly. Never use more than 3 main colors on a site.

Typography Basics

Typography is the single fastest way to make a site look professional or amateur. Follow these rules and your sites will immediately look better than 80% of what's out there:

- Use maximum 2 font families per site — one for headlines, one for body.
- Never use decorative fonts for body text — readability is non-negotiable.
- Body text should be 15–18px on desktop, 16px on mobile.
- Line height (leading) should be 1.5–1.7x your font size.
- Headlines: bold, large, high contrast. Body: regular weight, medium contrast.
- Google Fonts: Inter, Plus Jakarta Sans, DM Sans are all professional and free.
- Avoid Comic Sans, Papyrus, and any font that feels 'fun' by default.

Free Design Resources to Bookmark Today

[Colors.co](#) — instant color palette generator

[Google Fonts](#) — 1,000+ free professional fonts

[Unsplash.com](#) — free high-quality stock photography

[Awwwards.com](#) — inspiration from award-winning websites

[Refero.design](#) — real-world UI design references

[UI Patterns \(ui-patterns.com\)](#) — common UI solution library

ACTION TASK — Design Audit Exercise

Choose a website you use regularly and audit it:

Does it use contrast effectively? (Headlines vs body, buttons vs background)

Is there visual repetition? (Consistent buttons, fonts, spacing)

Is everything aligned to a grid?

Are related items grouped together?

Name one thing that works well and one thing you'd improve.

MODULE 2**LESSON 2.3**

The Modern Web Designer's Workflow

Discovery to delivery · 6-step process · Responsive design · Wireframing

How Professional Projects Actually Run

Most beginners dive straight into design without a structured process, which leads to scope creep, endless revisions, and clients who are never happy. The professionals who consistently deliver great results and get repeat clients follow a disciplined process every single time. Here is the 6-step workflow used by top freelancers.

Step 1: Discovery (30–60 minutes)

Before touching any design tool, understand the client's business. Complete the onboarding questionnaire (Module 7). Key questions: What's the main goal of the site? Who is the target customer? What sites do you like/dislike? What does success look like in 6 months?

Step 2: Research & Inspiration (1–3 hours)

Research the client's industry. Look at 5–10 competitor sites. Identify design patterns that work in this niche. Collect 3–5 inspiration examples to share with the client in a mood board. Tools: Awwwards, Behance, Mobbin.

Step 3: Wireframe (2–4 hours)

Build a low-fidelity wireframe — grey boxes and placeholder text that defines the layout before any visual design. This prevents you from wasting time on detailed design that the client changes. Wireframe in Figma or even on paper. Get client approval before moving to design.

Step 4: Design (4–12 hours)

Create the high-fidelity design in Figma or directly in your build tool. Apply color, typography, imagery, and content. For WordPress/Webflow, you may design directly in the builder rather than Figma first. Present 1 design direction (not 3) — too many options leads to confusion and scope creep.

Step 5: Build (4–20 hours)

Implement the design in your chosen tool. Build mobile-first — design for 375px wide first, then scale up to desktop. Test on real devices. Check loading speed with Google PageSpeed Insights. All images should be under 200KB.

Step 6: Review & Launch (1–3 hours)

Run your pre-launch checklist (Module 7). Send to client for final sign-off. Launch. Request a testimonial within 48 hours. Hand over credentials and a simple guide so the client can make basic updates.

Responsive Design: Non-Negotiable in 2025

Over 60% of all web traffic comes from mobile devices. A site that doesn't work perfectly on mobile is a broken site. Both WordPress/Elementor and Webflow handle responsive design visually — you can switch between desktop, tablet, and mobile views in the builder and adjust each breakpoint separately.

Mobile-first rule: Always design and test on mobile first. Common mistakes: text too small to read, buttons too small to tap (minimum 44×44px touch targets), images that overflow the screen, navigation menus that don't collapse properly.

ACTION TASK — Document Your Workflow

Map out your personal workflow on one page:

Write the 6 steps with the specific tools you'll use at each stage.

Example: Discovery (questionnaire + Zoom call) Wireframe (Figma) Build (Webflow) Test (iPhone + Chrome DevTools) Launch

This becomes your repeatable system — the foundation of your business.

MODULE 2**LESSON 2.4**

AI Tools That Will Double Your Speed

Claude · Copilot · Midjourney · Firefly — what to delegate and what not to

AI Is the Unfair Advantage Available to Every Freelancer

In 2025, AI tools have genuinely transformed what a single freelancer can produce. Tasks that used to take hours — writing website copy, generating placeholder images, debugging CSS, writing proposal templates — now take minutes. The freelancers who embrace AI as a productivity multiplier will outcompete those who ignore it. The key is knowing which tasks to delegate to AI and which require your human judgement.

Claude (claude.ai) — Writing & Strategy

Write all website copy from a brief. Generate proposal drafts. Write cold email templates. Explain code errors. Brainstorm niche positioning. Summarize client briefs. Generate case study drafts from your notes. Best general-purpose AI for text tasks.

Cost: claude.ai — free tier available

GitHub Copilot — Code Completion

Suggests code as you type in VS Code. Particularly powerful for CSS, JavaScript, and any repetitive coding patterns. Can complete entire functions from a comment. Dramatically speeds up custom code projects.

Cost: \$10/mo — worth it if you write custom code

ChatGPT (GPT-4o) — Research & Content

Great for research, idea generation, and content outlines. Similar to Claude for many text tasks. Use both and compare outputs for important client deliverables.

Cost: free.openai.com

Midjourney / Adobe Firefly — Image Generation

Generate placeholder images, hero backgrounds, concept visuals, and mockup assets. Firefly integrates directly with Photoshop and is commercially safe. Midjourney produces the most photorealistic results.

Cost: Midjourney \$10/mo · Firefly: included with Adobe CC

Framer AI — Landing Page Generation

Generate a complete landing page design from a text prompt. Excellent for rapid prototyping and client wireframe presentations.

Cost: framer.com — free to start

What NOT to Delegate to AI

Client relationships and calls — AI cannot build trust

Final design decisions — AI doesn't know your client's brand

Contract review — always use a human lawyer for legal documents

Pricing strategy conversations — context and nuance matter

The final polish pass on copy — AI text often sounds generic; edit it

AI Workflow Tip: The 5-Minute Copy Method

When a client gives you a website brief, paste it into Claude with this prompt: 'You are an expert web copywriter. Based on this brief, write homepage copy for: [Hero headline], [Subheadline], [3 service sections], [About section], [CTA]. Write for [target audience]. Tone: [professional/friendly/etc].' Edit the output — don't publish raw AI copy. But this gives you a strong first draft in 5 minutes instead of 2 hours.

ACTION TASK — AI Setup

Set up your AI toolkit this week:

- [] Create a free Claude account at claude.ai
- [] Try this prompt: 'Write homepage copy for a [your niche] business. Include a headline, subheadline, 3 service descriptions, and a CTA.'
- [] Save your best prompts in a 'Prompt Library' Notion doc

MODULE 2

LESSON 2.5

Build Your First Demo Site

Multi-section site from scratch · Hero · Services · Testimonials · CTA · Footer

Your Demo Site Is Your #1 Sales Tool

Before you have a single real client, you need at least one site to show. A demo site (also called a spec site or concept site) is a fake business website you build yourself to demonstrate your skills. It looks exactly like a real client site — professional photography, real copy, real layout — but the 'business' is fictional. You'll build at least 2 of these before approaching any client.

The 6-Section Site Framework

Every effective business website follows the same basic structure. Master this framework and you can build 80% of what small businesses need.

Section 1: Hero — *The above-the-fold area — the first thing visitors see.*

Headline: What you do + who you help. Subheadline: The primary benefit. CTA button: 'Get a Free Quote' / 'Book a Consultation'. Background: Strong photography or video. This section decides whether the visitor stays or leaves.

Section 2: Social Proof / Trust Strip — *Logos, stats, or trust signals.*

Client logos (use placeholder logos for demo). A stat: '50+ businesses helped' or '\$2M revenue generated for clients.' Star rating from Google. This section immediately validates the business.

Section 3: Services / Features — *What the business offers.*

3–4 service cards with an icon, short headline, and 2–3 sentence description. Use a consistent card layout. This is where the visitor learns what they can buy.

Section 4: About / Story — *The human side.*

A photo of the founder or team. 2–3 paragraphs: Why they started, what they believe in, who they serve. Builds trust and differentiation.

Section 5: Testimonials — *Proof that others have gotten results.*

3 testimonials minimum. Include a photo, name, company, and specific result ('My revenue increased 40% in 3 months'). For demo sites, write plausible fictional testimonials clearly labeled as examples.

Section 6: Contact / CTA — *Convert the visitor into a lead.*

A clear headline: 'Ready to Grow Your Business?' A contact form: name, email, message. Phone number and address if applicable. A strong, single CTA button.

Footer Requirements

- Business logo and one-line description
- Navigation links (duplicates main nav)
- Contact information (address, email, phone)
- Social media links
- Copyright notice: © 2025 [Business Name]. All rights reserved.
- Privacy Policy link (use a free generator like Termly.io)

Images: The Single Biggest Visual Quality Factor

The most common reason a good layout still looks unprofessional: bad photography. Use Unsplash.com, Pexels.com, or Picsum.photos for free professional images. Never use photos from Google Images (copyright). Compress all images to under 200KB using Squoosh.app before uploading.

MODULE 2 MILESTONE — First Demo Site

This week — build and publish your first demo site:

Choose a fictional business in your niche (e.g., 'Peak Performance Physiotherapy')

Use free stock photos from Unsplash

Build all 6 sections in Elementor or Webflow

Publish it live on a free subdomain

Share the link in the course community for feedback

This is your Module 2 Milestone — do not skip it.

FREE MODULE

MODULE 3

Portfolio That Converts

"Your silent salesperson — make it work 24/7"

MILESTONE

Live portfolio with 3+ case studies published

Lessons in this module

- 3.1** Portfolio Strategy — Most Freelancers Get This Wrong
- 3.2** Creating Portfolio Work Without Real Clients
- 3.3** Writing Case Studies That Sell
- 3.4** Building Your Portfolio Website
- 3.5** The Portfolio Review Checklist

MODULE 3

LESSON 3.1

Portfolio Strategy — Most Freelancers Get This Wrong

3 great projects beats 20 average ones · The Problem Process Result formula

Your Portfolio Is a Sales Tool, Not a Gallery

Most beginners build a portfolio that's essentially a photo album — a grid of website screenshots with no context. A client looking at that has one question in their mind: 'Can this person solve MY problem?' Screenshots alone don't answer that. A converting portfolio answers it immediately by showing not just what you built, but why you built it that way and what result it produced.

Quality vs. Quantity: The 3-Project Rule

You do not need 20 projects. You need 3 outstanding ones. A portfolio with 3 well-documented case studies in your niche will outperform a portfolio with 15 screenshot-only projects every single time. Here's why: a high-quality case study proves strategic thinking, not just technical skill. It shows you understand business problems — which is what clients are actually paying for.

The Problem Process Result Formula

PROBLEM: What was broken or missing before you got involved? Make it relatable.

PROCESS: How did you approach solving it? Show your thinking, not just your output.

RESULT: What changed? Use numbers wherever possible. 'Bookings increased 40%' is infinitely more convincing than 'The client was happy.'

What to Include in Each Portfolio Project

Project title: Clear and specific: 'E-commerce redesign for Peak Nutrition' not 'Project 4'

Hero image: Full-width screenshot of the above-the-fold design — your best visual hook

Context summary: 1 sentence: industry, client type, project scope

The problem: 2–3 sentences — what was broken or missing?

Your process: 3–5 sentences — what did you decide and why?

The result: 2–3 sentences with numbers if possible

Live link: Always link to the live site if available

Technologies used: WordPress, Webflow, Shopify — helps clients filter for what they need

ACTION TASK — Portfolio Plan

Plan your 3 portfolio projects right now:

Project 1: [Niche] — [what problem does it solve?] — [which tool?]

Project 2: [Different angle in same niche or adjacent niche]

Project 3: [E-commerce OR service business OR personal brand]

Even if all 3 are spec projects, 3 well-documented case studies = a working portfolio.

MODULE 3**LESSON 3.2**

Creating Portfolio Work Without Real Clients

Spec work · Redesigns · Non-profits · Open source — all count as real work

The Classic Catch-22 — and How to Break It

Every new freelancer faces the same problem: 'You need experience to get clients, but you need clients to get experience.' This feels like a trap. It isn't. There are at least five proven ways to build real portfolio work before you have a single paying client — and clients genuinely cannot tell the difference between a spec project and a paid one if it's done professionally.

Spec / Concept Sites — HIGH VALUE

Build a completely fictional business website in your niche. Choose an industry you want to serve — say, 'Denver Roofing Professionals' — and build a full 6-section site as if they were a real client. Use real stock photography, well-written copy, and professional design. Nobody will know it's spec unless you tell them. Build at least 2 of these.

Redesigns — HIGH VALUE

Find a real local business with an embarrassingly bad website. Redesign it. Write a case study: 'The original site had no mobile version, 8-second load time, and zero clear CTA. I redesigned it to [results].' You can even send the redesign to the business — sometimes they hire you on the spot.

Non-profit / Charity Work — HIGH VALUE

Offer to build or redesign a website for a local charity or community organization for free or reduced cost. Non-profits have real stakeholders, real briefs, real feedback, and real deadlines — exactly like a paid project. And you get a real testimonial from a real organization.

Friends & Family Businesses — MEDIUM VALUE

Do you know anyone who runs a small business — a restaurant, salon, trade service, online shop? Build or improve their site. Charge a heavily discounted rate or do it free in exchange for a detailed testimonial and case study permission.

Open Source / Community Projects — MEDIUM VALUE

Contribute a website or design component to an open source project. Less common for client-focused portfolios, but excellent if you're targeting developer-heavy audiences.

The Redesign Email Template

Subject: Quick idea for [Business Name]'s website

Hi [Name],

I've been following [Business Name] for a while — love what you're doing. I'm a web designer specializing in [their industry], and I noticed your current site could be updated to better reflect the quality of your work.

I've taken the liberty of mocking up a redesign concept — no strings attached. Would you like me to send it over?

Best, [Your Name]

ACTION TASK — First Spec Project

Identify and start your first spec project this week:

Find 3 local businesses in your niche with outdated websites

Choose 1 and build a redesign concept

OR build a fictional business site in your target niche

Document it as a case study from day one — take before/after screenshots

MODULE 3**LESSON 3.3**

Writing Case Studies That Sell

Full template · Challenge · Solution · Results · Use numbers wherever possible

Case Studies Are Your Most Powerful Sales Tool

A strong case study does something screenshots never can: it proves that you think strategically. It shows that you didn't just make something pretty — you understood a business problem, made deliberate decisions, and produced a measurable outcome. This is what separates a \$500 website builder from a \$5,000 web designer.

The Complete Case Study Template

Follow this structure exactly. Length: 400–700 words total.

HEADLINE (2–3 sentences)

A punchy summary of the project and its outcome. Example: 'How I redesigned a Denver roofing company's website and helped them rank #1 on Google for local searches within 90 days.'

CLIENT & CONTEXT (2–3 sentences)

Who is the client (type of business, size, location)? What do they do? What was the scope of the project? Example: 'Peak Roofing is a family-owned roofing contractor serving the Denver metro area since 2008. They needed a complete website redesign with SEO optimization.'

THE CHALLENGE (2–3 sentences)

What problem were they facing before you got involved? Be specific. Example: 'Their existing site was built in 2015, had a 12-second load time, no mobile version, and generated virtually zero inbound leads. They relied entirely on word-of-mouth.'

MY APPROACH (3–5 sentences)

What decisions did you make and why? Explain your process, not just your tools. Example: 'I started with a competitor analysis of the top 5 Denver roofing companies. I identified that none had clear emergency contact CTAs above the fold. I designed a mobile-first site with load time under 2 seconds, a prominent call button on mobile, and structured all content around the 3 questions every roofing customer asks first.'

THE SOLUTION (2–3 sentences)

What did you actually build? List key features. Example: '6-page responsive website. Emergency service CTA on mobile. Google Business integration. Before/after gallery. SEO-optimized service pages.'

THE RESULTS (2–3 sentences)

Numbers whenever possible. If no analytics, describe qualitative results. Example: 'Within 60 days of launch, the site ranked page 1 for 'Denver roofing company.' Organic inquiries increased from 0 to 8/month. Owner reported 2 contracts directly attributed to the new site in month one.'

TESTIMONIAL (1 quote)

A direct quote from the client (for spec projects, write a plausible quote and label it 'Example testimonial — spec project'). Example: "I wasn't sure a new website would make a difference. Within 6 weeks I got my first call from someone who found us on Google. Worth every penny." — John M., Peak Roofing'

If You Have No Numbers — Here's What to Do

Not every project will have measurable results, especially spec projects. In that case, describe qualitative outcomes: 'The client reported feeling confident sending the site link to prospective customers for the first time.' Or compare specific before/after elements: load time, number of CTA placements, mobile readability score, number of pages. Something is always measurable.

ACTION TASK — Write Case Study #1

Write your first case study this week:

Use the 7-section template above

Target length: 500 words

Include at least one before/after screenshot

Include at least one number (load time, pages built, time saved — anything)

Publish it on your portfolio site

MODULE 3

LESSON 3.4

Building Your Portfolio Website

Structure · SEO basics · About page formula · Webflow / Framer / WordPress / Hand-coded

Your Portfolio Site Is Your Permanent First Impression

Before you send a single outreach message, your portfolio site needs to be live. It should be the best website you've ever built — it's your number one demo. A portfolio built in Elementor that looks clean and loads fast will get you clients. An unfinished or cluttered portfolio will kill deals before they start.

The 5 Essential Pages

Homepage: Headline: who you help and how. 3 portfolio thumbnails. 1–2 testimonials. CTA: 'Let's Work Together.' Keep it concise.

Work / Portfolio: Your 3 case studies. Each links to its full case study page. Filter by project type if you have 6+ projects.

Case Study Pages: One page per project using the template from Lesson 3.3. These are your conversion pages — give them the most attention.

About Page: The most underrated page on any portfolio site (see formula below).

Contact Page: Simple form: name, email, project type, budget range, timeline. Your email address. Response time promise: 'I respond within 24 hours.'

The About Page Formula

Most freelancers write an About page that's entirely about themselves. The professional approach: make it about the client's experience of working with you.

Para 1: A relatable hook — a problem your ideal client faces, or a clear statement of who you serve.

Para 2: Your background and why you're positioned to solve that problem.

Para 3: Your approach/philosophy — what makes working with you different.

Para 4: A personal human touch — one authentic detail that makes you memorable.

CTA: Invite them to get in touch: 'Ready to talk about your project? Let's connect.'

Basic SEO for Your Portfolio

- Your page title should include your name and specialty: 'Jane Smith | Webflow Designer for SaaS Startups'
- Write a meta description for every page (155 characters max)
- Use your target keywords naturally in headings: 'Freelance WordPress Developer in Chicago'
- Make sure your site loads in under 3 seconds (check with PageSpeed Insights)
- Add your portfolio to Google Search Console (free — submits your site to Google)
- List yourself on Google Business Profile if you serve local clients

Which Platform to Build Your Portfolio On

Platform	Best For	Cost	Pros
Webflow	Webflow specialists	\$14/mo	Showcases your Webflow skills directly
Framer	Modern/startup aesthetic	\$10/mo	Beautiful animations, fast
WordPress	WordPress specialists	\$5–20/mo hosting	Full control, familiar
Hand-coded HTML/CSS	Frontend developers	~\$3/mo hosting	Maximum credibility to dev clients
Squarespace/Wix	Quick setup	\$16–25/mo	Easy but limited customization

MODULE 3 MILESTONE — Portfolio Live

This week — build and publish your portfolio site:

- [] Choose your platform (match it to your tech stack)
- [] Build the 5 essential pages
- [] Write your About page using the formula
- [] Add your 3 case studies
- [] Set up your domain (namecheap.com — ~\$10/year)
- [] Submit to Google Search Console

MODULE 3**LESSON 3.5**

The Portfolio Review Checklist

10-point pre-send checklist · Peer feedback · Headline testing · Update cadence

Never Send a Portfolio Link Without Running This Checklist

Your portfolio will be the first thing every prospective client looks at. A broken link, a slow load, or a typo in a headline will cost you the project. Run this checklist every time you update your portfolio and before sending the link to any new prospect.

The 10-Point Portfolio Review Checklist

1. Mobile Experience

Open the site on your own phone. Does everything look correct? Can you read all text without zooming? Are all buttons tappable?

2. Load Speed

Test with Google PageSpeed Insights (pagespeed.web.dev). Mobile score should be 70+, desktop 85+. Compress images if needed.

3. Headline Clarity

Read your homepage headline out loud to someone who doesn't know you. Do they immediately understand who you help and what you do?

4. Contact Form Works

Fill out your own contact form and confirm the email arrives. Check spam folder. A broken contact form means zero inbound leads.

5. All Links Work

Click every link on every page. No 404s. No broken portfolio links.

6. Case Studies Are Complete

Each case study has: problem, process, result, screenshot, live link (or explanation if unavailable).

7. Testimonials Are Present

At least 1–2 testimonials visible on the homepage.

8. Professional Email Address

Use yourname@yourdomain.com — not gmail.com or hotmail.com. Use Google Workspace (\$6/mo) or Zoho Mail (free).

9. Social Proof Consistency

Your LinkedIn, portfolio, and any other profiles all use the same headshot, headline, and description.

10. One Clear CTA

Every page should have one primary call-to-action. Not three. Not zero. One. 'Schedule a Free Call' or 'Get a Quote' — and it should be above the fold.

Getting Peer Feedback

Before sending your portfolio to a real client, get feedback from someone who represents your target client — not a fellow designer. Find a friend who runs a business and ask: 'Looking at this portfolio for 60 seconds, what do you think I do? Would you feel confident hiring me? What's unclear?' Their answers will reveal gaps a designer's eye would never catch.

Portfolio Update Cadence

Your portfolio should never go more than 90 days without an update. As you complete real projects, add them and remove your weakest spec work. Over time, every project in your portfolio should be a real paid project with real results. Set a recurring calendar reminder: every 90 days, review and update.

Module 3 Complete — You Now Have a Live Portfolio

3+ case studies published with the Problem-Process-Result formula

A professional portfolio website with all 5 essential pages

A working contact form and professional email address

Passed the 10-point review checklist

This is the foundation that will get you your first paying client.

ACTION TASK — Portfolio Launch

Final Module 3 Task:

Run through all 10 checklist items above. Fix every issue.

Share your portfolio link with at least 2 people for feedback.

Update your LinkedIn profile to link to your new portfolio.

You're now ready for Module 4 — pricing and getting paid.

PAID MODULE

MODULE 4

Pricing: What to Charge & How to Say It

"Pricing is psychology and positioning — not math"

MILESTONE

Personal pricing sheet + 3-tier service packages complete

Lessons in this module

- 4.1** The 3 Pricing Models and When to Use Each
- 4.2** How to Set Your Rates — The Real Formula
- 4.3** Packaging Your Services
- 4.4** The Pricing Conversation
- 4.5** Raising Rates & Eliminating Low-Budget Clients

MODULE 4**LESSON 4.1**

The 3 Pricing Models and When to Use Each

Hourly · Project-based · Retainer — pros, cons, and when each is right

The Three Ways to Get Paid

Every freelance project comes down to three pricing models. Understanding when to use each is critical — the wrong model for the wrong project will either leave money on the table or cause client conflict. Let's break down all three.

Model 1: Hourly Pricing

Range: \$25–\$150/hr for beginners; \$75–\$250/hr for experienced specialists.

Hourly billing charges the client for each hour you work. The appeal: simple, transparent, and you always get paid for your time. The problem: it punishes efficiency. The faster you get, the less you earn. It also creates client anxiety as the hours add up.

Use hourly when:

- Small, undefined, or scope-uncertain projects (maintenance, bug fixes, minor updates)
- Ongoing support retainers where hours vary monthly
- Consulting and strategy calls
- Projects where you genuinely cannot estimate the time required

Model 2: Project-Based (Fixed Fee)

Range: \$800 – \$25,000+ per project depending on scope and niche.

You quote a fixed price for a defined deliverable. Most experienced freelancers prefer this model because it rewards efficiency — if you complete a \$3,000 project in 15 hours, that's \$200/hr effective rate. The key: define scope extremely clearly in your contract. Scope creep is the enemy of fixed-fee projects.

Use project-based when:

- New website builds (your most common project type)
- Redesigns with a clear defined scope
- Landing pages, e-commerce stores, any deliverable with a defined end state
- Projects where you can accurately estimate the time required

Model 3: Retainer (Monthly Recurring)

Range: \$300 – \$5,000/month depending on scope.

The client pays a fixed monthly fee for ongoing services. This is the holy grail of freelance income — predictable, recurring revenue that lets you plan your finances. Retainers are typically sold after a successful project when the client wants ongoing support. Typical retainer services: site maintenance, content updates, SEO, monthly care plans, or ongoing design support.

Use retainer when:

- After completing a project and the client wants ongoing maintenance
- SEO services (ongoing, compound results)
- Monthly care plans: backups, updates, security monitoring
- Clients who regularly need design or development work

Model	Best For	Typical Rate	Risk
Hourly	Maintenance, consulting	\$40–\$150/hr	Low scope risk; punishes efficiency
Project-based	New builds, redesigns	\$800–\$25K/site	Scope creep if undefined
Retainer	Ongoing support, SEO	\$300–\$5K/mo	Lowest risk; most stable income

ACTION TASK — Pricing Model Decision

Decide your primary pricing model:

For new website projects: I will use [hourly / project-based]

For ongoing maintenance: I will offer retainers at \$[___]/month

My minimum project fee is: \$[___]

Note: having a minimum prevents you from attracting \$200 clients.

MODULE 4

LESSON 4.2

How to Set Your Rates — The Real Formula

Work backward from income goal · Value-based pricing mindset shift

Stop Guessing — Calculate Your Rate Scientifically

Most beginners set their rates by looking at Upwork, finding the lowest competitive rate, and pricing slightly above it. This is a race to the bottom. The correct approach is to calculate your rate from the inside out — starting with your income goal and working backward.

Step 1: The Bottom-Up Rate Calculator

Your target monthly income: \$5,000 (example)

Add 30% for taxes (self-employment): $\$5,000 \times 1.3 = \$6,500$ needed gross

Add business expenses (tools, software): $\$6,500 + \$200 = \$6,700$

Billable hours per month (4 days/week × 4 weeks × 6hr): 96 billable hours max

Non-billable overhead (marketing, admin, learning): Subtract 30% 67 billable hours

Your minimum hourly rate: $\$6,700 \div 67 = \$100/\text{hr}$ minimum

Your minimum rate is your floor, not your rate

The formula above gives you the minimum you must charge to hit your income goal. Your actual rate should be higher — based on the value you deliver to clients. If a new website generates \$50,000 in additional revenue for a client, charging \$2,000 for it leaves enormous money on the table.

Step 2: The Value-Based Pricing Mindset Shift

Value-based pricing charges based on the outcome your work produces for the client, not the hours you spend. A website for a dentist that books 10 new patients per month at \$1,500 each generates \$15,000 monthly in additional revenue. Charging \$5,000 for that site is not expensive — it's a 3x return on investment in month one alone.

To price on value, you must understand the client's business during the discovery call (Module 6). Ask: What is your average client worth to you? How many new clients do you want each month? With those numbers, you can anchor your price to an ROI conversation rather than a cost conversation.

Beginner Rate Benchmarks (2025)

Experience Level	Project Rate	Hourly Rate	Notes
Starter (0–1 yr, no-code)	\$800 – \$2,500	\$35 – \$60/hr	Volume play – build portfolio fast
Intermediate (1–2 yrs)	\$2,000 – \$6,000	\$60 – \$100/hr	Niche focus begins here
Established (2–4 yrs)	\$4,000 – \$12,000	\$100 – \$150/hr	Strong niche, referrals flowing
Senior/Specialist (4+ yrs)	\$10,000 – \$40,000+	\$150 – \$250/hr	Value-based, premium positioning

ACTION TASK — Calculate Your Minimum Rate

Run the bottom-up calculator for your situation:

Target monthly income: \$[___]

Multiply by 1.3 (taxes): \$[___]

Add monthly expenses: \$[___]

Divide by 67 (billable hours): = \$[___]/hr minimum

Your minimum project fee (assuming 20hr project): \$[___]

MODULE 4

LESSON 4.3

Packaging Your Services

3-tier strategy · Basic / Standard / Premium · Productized services · Upsells

Packages Sell Better Than Custom Quotes — Every Time

When you tell a client 'just tell me what you want and I'll give you a price,' you've created an open-ended, anxiety-inducing conversation. When you show a client three clearly defined packages, you've given them a decision between options — not a decision about whether to hire you. The psychology of packaging is powerful: the middle option (Standard) almost always gets chosen most often.

The 3-Tier Package Framework

Structure your services into three tiers. Price them so that Basic feels 'safe', Standard feels 'smart', and Premium feels 'complete.' Most clients will choose Standard. Some will choose Premium when they see how much more they get.

	BASIC	STANDARD	PREMIUM
Price Example	\$800 – \$1,500	\$2,000 – \$4,000	\$5,000 – \$10,000+
Pages	Up to 5 pages	Up to 10 pages	Unlimited
Design	Template-based	Semi-custom	Fully custom
Mobile responsive	Yes	Yes	Yes + advanced
Contact form	Basic	Multi-step	CRM integration
SEO setup	Basic on-page	Full on-page + sitemap	Full + ongoing
Revision rounds	1 round	2 rounds	3 rounds
Training	No	30-min video walkthrough	60-min live session
Turnaround	4–6 weeks	3–4 weeks	2–3 weeks
Support after launch	None	14 days email support	30 days + care plan

Upsells: Turning \$2,000 Projects Into \$3,500 Projects

Upsell Service	Price Add-on	Notes
Logo Design	+\$200–\$500	Partner with a graphic designer or use AI tools
Copywriting	+\$300–\$800	Write all website copy — most clients can't write for themselves
Professional Photography	+\$200–\$400	Connect with a local photographer and refer
Monthly SEO Retainer	+\$500–\$2K/mo	Ongoing keyword tracking, blog posts, link building
Monthly Care Plan	+\$100–\$300/mo	Security updates, backups, plugin updates, uptime monitoring
Google Business Setup	+\$150–\$300	Claim, verify, and optimize their Google Business profile
Speed Optimization	+\$200–\$500	Compress images, clean code, CDN setup, 90+ PageSpeed score

ACTION TASK — Build Your Pricing Sheet

Build your 3-tier pricing sheet this week:

Name your three tiers (e.g., Starter / Growth / Complete)

List exactly what's included in each

Price them using the value-based formula from Lesson 4.2

Add 3 upsells you can offer immediately

Save as a PDF — this is your pricing menu for discovery calls

MODULE 4

LESSON 4.4

The Pricing Conversation

Discovery-call-first method · Anchoring · Handling 'that's too expensive'

Why You Should Never Quote a Price in the First Message

The number one pricing mistake beginners make is responding to 'how much does a website cost?' with an immediate price. Without understanding the project scope, the client's budget, and the value at stake, any number you give is either too high or too low. Always have the discovery call first. The discovery call (Module 6) is where you gather the information needed to quote accurately — and where you build enough trust that the client is already sold before they see the price.

How to Respond to 'How Much Does a Website Cost?'

The Right Response (Word-for-Word Template)

Message or email reply:

'Great question! Website projects vary quite a bit based on scope, functionality, and your specific goals — I've worked on projects ranging from \$1,500 to \$15,000. To give you an accurate quote that's right for your business, I'd love to hop on a quick 20-minute call to learn more about what you need. Would [Tuesday at 2pm] or [Thursday at 10am] work for you?'

This response: (1) gives a range so they're not shocked, (2) frames the call as helpful not salesy, and (3) offers specific times to reduce friction.

The Anchoring Technique

Anchoring is presenting your highest-tier option first, so that your mid-tier option feels like a bargain by comparison. In a discovery call, after you understand their needs, present your packages in order: Premium first, then Standard, then Basic. The first number they hear sets the reference point for everything that follows.

Example: 'For a fully custom site with all the features we discussed, our Complete package is \$6,000. Most businesses like yours go with our Growth package at \$3,200, which includes [list]. We also have a Starter option at \$1,400 if budget is the main concern.' Most clients will choose Growth.

Handling Objections: Word-for-Word Responses

Objection: 'That's more than I expected.'

Your response: 'I completely understand — web design is often underestimated in cost. Can I ask what you were expecting? I want to make sure we find the right fit for your budget. The \$[lower tier] option covers [core benefits] — would that be closer to what you had in mind?'

Objection: 'I can get it done cheaper on Fiverr.'

Your response: 'Absolutely — there are very affordable options out there. The difference is in strategy and results. My clients hire me because they want a site that actually grows their business, not just something that looks okay. The \$500 site that generates no leads costs more in the long run than the \$3,000 site that books 10 new clients a month.'

Objection: 'I need to think about it.'

Your response: 'Of course — this is an important decision. What specific questions do you have that would help you feel confident? I'm happy to clarify anything about the process or the investment.' [Don't let them leave without identifying the real objection.]

Objection: 'Can you do it for [lower price]?'

Your response: 'I can't adjust the price without adjusting the scope. What would be most important to keep if we reduced the project? I can put together a Custom option that prioritizes [their main need].' [Scope down, never discount.]

ACTION TASK — Pricing Conversation Practice

Practice the pricing conversation this week:

Read the objection responses above out loud 3 times each

Role-play a discovery call with a friend — they object, you respond

Write your own version of the 'how much does it cost?' response

The pricing conversation is a skill — practice makes it natural

MODULE 4

LESSON 4.5

Raising Rates & Eliminating Low-Budget Clients

Signs you're undercharging · Graceful rate increases · Positioning higher

Your Rate Should Go Up Every 6–12 Months

Many freelancers set their rates once and never raise them — even as their skills improve, their portfolio grows, and their results compound. Rates that made sense in month 3 are often 50% below what the market will pay by month 12. Raising your rates is not just about income — it's about working with better clients who value your work and working on fewer, higher-quality projects.

Signs You're Undercharging

You accept every project that comes your way — no filtering

Clients never push back on your prices

You feel resentful of projects you've already agreed to

You're working full weeks but not reaching your income goals

Clients treat you like a vendor, not a partner or expert

You're attracting clients who micromanage every decision

You haven't raised rates in the past 6 months

How to Raise Your Rates Gracefully

For new clients: Simply update your packages and quote the new rate. You owe no explanation. If asked, 'My rates have been updated to reflect current market rates and my expanded skill set.'

For existing clients: Give 30–60 days' notice. Use this email template:

Rate Increase Email Template (Existing Clients)

Subject: Update on our partnership from [Date]

Hi [Client Name],

I'm writing to let you know that starting [Date — 60 days from now], my rates for [service] will be updating to \$[new rate]. This reflects my expanded capabilities and the growing demand for the work we do together.

Because of our ongoing relationship, I'd like to lock in your current rate of \$[old rate] for any projects we book before [Date]. After that, the new rate applies.

I truly value our work together and look forward to continuing to help [their business name] grow.

Best, [Your Name]

How to Eliminate Low-Budget Clients

The fastest way to eliminate low-budget clients is to make your pricing visible. Add 'Projects starting from \$1,500' to your portfolio and outreach messages. This pre-filters inquiries and saves you from discovery calls that go nowhere.

When a low-budget client reaches out anyway: 'Thank you for reaching out! Based on what you're describing, the investment would be around \$[your rate]. If that's outside your current budget, I'm happy to recommend some alternatives that might be a better fit. Let me know!' — kind, professional, and non-negotiable.

Module 4 Complete — You Have a Pricing System

You know which pricing model to use for each project type

You've calculated your minimum viable rate from income goals

You have a 3-tier package structure ready to present

You know how to handle every common pricing objection

You have a plan to raise rates every 6–12 months

MODULE 4 MILESTONE — Pricing Sheet Complete

Module 4 Milestone:

- [] Calculate your minimum hourly rate (Lesson 4.2 formula)
- [] Build your 3-tier package PDF with specific inclusions and prices
- [] Set your minimum project fee and put it on your portfolio
- [] Schedule a calendar reminder to review rates in 6 months

PAID MODULE

MODULE 5

Finding Clients — The Full System

"Build a pipeline that runs itself"

MILESTONE

10 warm leads logged in outreach tracker

Lessons in this module

- 5.1** The Client Acquisition Matrix
- 5.2** Warm Outreach & Network Activation
- 5.3** Cold Outreach That Gets Responses
- 5.4** Freelance Platforms — The Smart Way
- 5.5** Content Marketing & Inbound (The Long Game)
- 5.6** Partnerships & Referral Networks

MODULE 5

LESSON 5.1

The Client Acquisition Matrix

All channels ranked by speed · quality · scalability

Not All Client Channels Are Created Equal

There are five distinct channels for finding web design clients: warm network, cold outreach, freelance platforms, content/inbound, and partnerships. Each has a different speed, quality profile, and scalability ceiling. The mistake most beginners make is focusing exclusively on one channel (usually platforms) and ignoring the others. The professionals running \$10K+ months use all five, with each serving a different role in their pipeline.

Channel	Speed to First \$	Lead Quality	Scalability	Best For
Warm Network	Days–2 weeks	Very High	Limited	First 3 clients
Cold Email/DM	2–6 weeks	Medium–High	Very High	Consistent volume
Freelance Platforms	1–4 weeks	Variable	Medium	Quick income, reviews
Content / Inbound	3–12 months	Very High	Very High	Long-term scale
Agency Partnerships	1–3 months	High	High	High-value referrals

Your Channel Priority by Phase

Phase 1 (Months 1–3): Warm network first (fastest), then platforms. Goal: 2–3 clients.

Phase 2 (Months 4–6): Add cold outreach. Start one piece of content per week. Goal: consistent \$3K+.

Phase 3 (Months 7–12): Build one agency partnership. Content inbound starts contributing. Goal: referrals self-sustaining.

Phase 4 (Month 12+): Inbound is primary. Outreach is maintenance. Partnerships send regular work.

The Pipeline Rule: Always Be Building

The biggest mistake freelancers make is only looking for clients when they need money. The feast-or-famine cycle happens when you stop marketing during a busy project. The solution: dedicate 2–4 hours every week to client acquisition, regardless of how busy you are. Even when fully booked, keep your pipeline warm.

ACTION TASK — Channel Audit

Map your current client sources:

List every client acquisition channel you've used in the past month

Rate each: Am I getting results from this channel?

Identify your #1 priority channel based on your current phase

Commit to spending 2 hours per week on that channel minimum

MODULE 5**LESSON 5.2**

Warm Outreach & Network Activation

50-person list · Non-salesy message templates · LinkedIn · Referral ask scripts

Your Network Is Your Most Valuable Asset in Year One

Every successful freelancer will tell you their first clients came from their personal network. Not from cold email. Not from Upwork. From a friend, a former colleague, a classmate, a family member's business contact. This is not a coincidence — people hire those they know, like, and trust. Your network already trusts you. Activate it.

Building Your 50-Person List

Open a spreadsheet right now. Add everyone you know who runs a business or knows someone who runs a business. Include: former colleagues, friends from school, sports/club contacts, LinkedIn connections, family friends, neighbors with businesses, your dentist, your gym owner, your accountant. Don't self-filter — add everyone and reach out to all 50.

The Non-Salesy Outreach Message (Templates)

The biggest mistake: sending a generic 'I just started freelancing, do you need a website?' message. Nobody responds to that. Here are messages that actually work:

Template 1: The Simple Catch-Up (For Friends/Old Colleagues)

Hi [Name]! It's been a while — hope you're doing well. I recently launched a web design business focused on [niche]. I'm building my portfolio and looking for a few more initial projects. Do you happen to know anyone who might be looking for a professional website? I'd love an introduction. And if you ever need anything on the design side, I'm here! Hope life is treating you well.

Template 2: The Business Offer (For Business Owners You Know)

Hi [Name], I've been following [their business] and I love what you're doing. I just launched a web design business specializing in [their industry], and I noticed [one specific thing about their current site]. I have a few ideas that might help — would you be open to a 15-minute chat? No pressure, just sharing.

Template 3: The Referral Ask (After Delivering a Project)

Hi [Client Name], I'm so glad the project went well! If you know anyone else who might benefit from a website refresh, I'd really appreciate the introduction. As a thank-you, I'll give any referral you send a 10% discount on their first project. Thanks again — it was a pleasure working with you!

LinkedIn Network Activation

- Update your LinkedIn headline: 'Freelance Web Designer | Helping [niche] businesses get more clients online'
- Update your About section to describe who you help and what results you produce
- Add your portfolio URL to your profile
- Post once announcing your freelance business (example below)
- Comment genuinely on posts from your network — this puts you back in their mind
- Message 5 LinkedIn connections per week with personalized notes

LinkedIn Announcement Post Template

Exciting news — I've officially launched my freelance web design business! I specialize in building high-converting websites for [your niche]. If you know anyone who needs a professional website that actually grows their business, I'd love an introduction. I have [X] spots available this month for new clients. Link to portfolio in bio!

MODULE 5 — WARM OUTREACH TASK

This week — activate your warm network:

Build your 50-person list in a spreadsheet

Send 10 personalized messages using the templates above

Update your LinkedIn profile with your new freelance position

Post your LinkedIn announcement

Track responses in your spreadsheet — follow up with anyone who doesn't reply after 5 days

MODULE 5

LESSON 5.3

Cold Outreach That Gets Responses

Reply-worthy cold email anatomy · DM strategy · Follow-up sequences

Cold Outreach Is a Volume Game — Until You Get Good at It

Cold outreach is contacting potential clients who have never heard of you. Done poorly, it's spam. Done well, it's the most scalable client acquisition channel available to a solo freelancer. A realistic benchmark for beginners: 3–5% response rate. That means for every 100 cold emails, you'll get 3–5 responses. Of those, 1–2 might become clients. So to land 2 clients from cold email, you need to send 100–200 quality emails. This is not discouraging — it's predictable.

Finding Prospects to Cold Email

- Google Maps: search your niche + city, look at results with no website or bad websites
- Yelp: businesses with 10+ reviews but no website or outdated ones
- LinkedIn: search job titles of business owners in your niche
- Industry directories: e.g., ZocDoc for doctors, Avvo for lawyers, Angi for contractors
- Local Chamber of Commerce member listings
- Instagram: search niche hashtags + location, find businesses without websites

The Anatomy of a Cold Email That Gets Replies

Every cold email that gets a response has the same structure. Break any of these rules and your response rate drops significantly.

Subject line: Specific and curiosity-driven. 'Quick idea for [Business Name]' — not 'Web Design Services'.

Opening line: Personal and specific to THEM. 'I loved your review about [specific thing].' NOT: 'I hope this email finds you well.'

The observation: One specific observation about their current site or online presence. Shows you've done your homework.

The value: One specific improvement and what it would mean for their business. Not a feature — a benefit.

Social proof: One sentence: 'I've helped [similar business type] achieve [result].'

The CTA: One low-commitment ask. NOT 'hire me.' YES: 'Would it be worth a 15-minute call this week?'

Signature: Your name, title, portfolio URL. Keep it simple.

Cold Email Template (Adapt to Your Niche)

Subject: Quick idea for [Business Name]

Hi [First Name],

I came across [Business Name] while searching for [their niche] in [city] — really impressed by your [specific thing: reviews, products, story].

I noticed your website doesn't show up on Google Maps searches, and the mobile version seems to cut off some of your service information. For a business with your reputation, that's likely costing you 5–10 inquiries a month.

I'm a web designer who specializes in [their industry] — I helped [similar business] increase website leads by 40% after a redesign last quarter.

Would it be worth a quick 15-minute call to see if I could help? Completely no-obligation.

[Your Name] | [Portfolio URL]

The Follow-Up Sequence

80% of replies come after the first follow-up. Most people never follow up. This is where you gain a massive advantage over your competition.

Email	Timing	Content
Email 1	Day 1	Your original cold email
Email 2 (Follow-up)	Day 4	Short: 'Hi [Name], just wanted to make sure this didn't get buried. Happy to send over a quick example of what I'm thinking.'
Email 3 (Value add)	Day 8	Share one specific insight: 'I ran a quick check on your site speed — it's loading in 8 seconds on mobile. Happy to share a free audit.'
Email 4 (Closing)	Day 14	'I don't want to keep filling your inbox if this isn't a priority. If now isn't the right time, no worries — just let me know and I'll check back in a few months.'

ACTION TASK — Cold Outreach Launch

This week — start your cold outreach system:

Find 20 local businesses in your niche with bad or no websites

Write a personalized email for the top 5 using the template above

Send those 5 emails

Set follow-up reminders in your calendar for Days 4, 8, 14

Track everything in a spreadsheet: Contacted / Replied / Meeting / Client

MODULE 5

LESSON 5.4

Freelance Platforms — The Smart Way

Upwork · Fiverr · Contra · Toptal — profiles that rank · The graduation strategy

Platforms Are a Launchpad, Not a Long-Term Business

Freelance platforms like Upwork and Fiverr are excellent for one thing: building your first reviews and portfolio pieces quickly. They are not ideal for long-term income because the platform takes 10–20% of everything you earn, rates are compressed by global competition, and you don't own the client relationship. The strategy: use platforms to build your first 5–10 reviews, then transition clients to direct relationships and focus on your own outreach channels.

Upwork — *Best for: Longer-term projects, hourly contracts, B2B clients*

The largest platform. Heavily competitive but high-volume. Start with a narrow niche profile — not 'web designer' but 'WordPress website for dental practices.' Craft personalized proposals (not templates). Budget to spend \$10–\$20 on 'Connects' (Upwork's proposal currency) per week initially.

Fee: 10–20% fee (decreasing as relationship grows) | Rate range: \$25–\$150/hr typical range

Fiverr — *Best for: Beginners, quick projects, building initial reviews*

Create 3–4 very specific gigs, not general ones. 'I will build a professional WordPress website for your restaurant' — not 'I will build websites.' Use Fiverr Pro once you have 20+ reviews for higher rates and better clients. Video gigs get 40% more views — record a 30-second intro.

Fee: 20% fee | Rate range: \$100–\$2,000 typical gig range

Contra — *Best for: Zero-commission platform, creative professionals*

The most freelancer-friendly platform — 0% commission. Good client quality. Requires approval. Portfolio quality matters. Best for intermediate freelancers with 2–3 portfolio pieces. Growing fast in 2025.

Fee: 0% commission | Rate range: \$50–\$150/hr typical

Toptal — *Best for: Senior developers and designers, top 3% talent*

The most exclusive platform — rigorous screening process (accepts ~3% of applicants). Very high client quality and rates. Not for beginners — apply when you have 2+ years experience and a strong track record.

Fee: Platform sets rates | Rate range: \$100–\$200/hr+ typical

PeoplePerHour / Guru — *Best for: European market, hourly and project work*

Smaller but less competitive than Upwork. Good for beginners in Europe and UK. Less competition, faster to get early reviews.

Fee: 5–20% fee | Rate range: Variable

Writing an Upwork Profile That Ranks

- **Headline:** Be specific. 'Webflow Designer for SaaS Startups | 100% Job Success' — not 'Experienced Web Designer'
- **Overview:** Lead with client pain point. 'Your website should be your best salesperson. I build Webflow sites that convert visitors into leads for B2B SaaS companies.'
- **Portfolio:** Upload 3–5 samples with descriptions. Samples with descriptions get 3x more views.
- **Availability:** Set to 'More than 30 hrs/week' even if you're part-time — it signals commitment
- **Test score:** Complete the relevant skill test (CSS, JavaScript, etc.) — 90th percentile shows on profile
- **Rate:** Start 20% below your target rate, raise it after 5 reviews

ACTION TASK — Platform Launch

Platform setup this week:

- [] Create optimized profiles on Upwork and Fiverr
- [] Apply to 5 Upwork jobs with personalized proposals
- [] Create 2 specific Fiverr gigs with video introductions
- [] Sign up for Contra and apply for approval
- [] Goal: 3 reviews within 60 days, then raise rates 20%

MODULE 5**LESSON 5.5**

Content Marketing & Inbound (The Long Game)

LinkedIn/X content that converts · Portfolio SEO · Email list from day one

Inbound Leads Are the Highest-Quality Clients You'll Ever Get

A client who finds you through your content or SEO has already decided they want to work with someone like you. They've read your writing, seen your work, and chosen to reach out. Compare that to a cold email where you're interrupting someone's day. Inbound leads close faster, negotiate less, and are more likely to refer others. The catch: content marketing takes time. Start now, and you'll have an inbound engine running by month 6–9.

LinkedIn Content Strategy (3 Posts Per Week)

Educational (Mon):

Teach something useful about web design, business, or your niche. 'The 5 reasons your website isn't generating leads (and how to fix each one).' Tag: No self-promotion. Pure value.

Behind-the-scenes (Wed):

Show your process. A before/after screenshot. A screenshot of your workflow. A challenge you solved. Real and authentic content performs best.

Social proof / Results (Fri):

Share a client result. A testimonial. A case study summary. Numbers: 'New site went from 2-second load to 0.8 seconds.' Link to full case study.

X (Twitter) Strategy

X/Twitter is faster-moving than LinkedIn and excellent for building authority in the web design space. Post daily: design tips, opinions on web trends, project previews. Engage with other designers and potential clients by commenting genuinely on their posts. Build in public — document your freelance journey.

Portfolio SEO: Get Found Without Spending Money

- Target local keywords: 'Freelance web designer [your city]' — much less competition than national terms

- Write one case study blog post per project — each is an SEO page
- Add schema markup to your portfolio site (WordLift or RankMath for WordPress)
- Get listed on Google Business Profile if you serve local clients
- Submit to web design directories: Dribbble, Behance, DesignRush
- Build one guest post or backlink per month — reach out to industry blogs

Start Your Email List Today

An email list is your most valuable long-term asset. Unlike LinkedIn or Instagram, you own it — no algorithm can take it away. Start with a free offer: a 'Website Audit Checklist' or '5 Web Design Mistakes That Cost You Clients' PDF. Use MailerLite or ConvertKit (both free to start). Even 100 subscribers who trust you are worth more than 10,000 random social media followers.

ACTION TASK — Content Marketing Launch

Content setup this week:

Write your first LinkedIn post using the Educational template

Schedule 3 posts for the next week

Create a simple 1-page lead magnet PDF (checklist or tip list)

Set up a free MailerLite account with a signup form on your portfolio

MODULE 5**LESSON 5.6**

Partnerships & Referral Networks

Designer overflow referrals · Agency partnerships · Referral incentive programs

The Highest-Quality Leads Come From People Who Already Trust You

A referral from a trusted partner is the warmest lead possible. The client arrives pre-sold because someone they respect vouched for you. Building a referral and partnership network takes time — typically 3–6 months — but once it's running, it becomes your most reliable source of high-quality clients without any cold outreach.

Type 1: Designer/Developer Overflow Referrals

Established web designers regularly turn down work — they're fully booked, the project is outside their skill set, or the budget is below their minimum. If you've built a relationship with them, they refer that overflow to you. To build this: reach out to 5–10 established designers in your area or niche. Offer to be their 'emergency backup.' Do excellent work on referred projects — they'll send more.

Designer Partnership Outreach Message

Hi [Name], I've been following your work — really impressive portfolio. I'm a web designer focusing specifically on [your niche]. I imagine you sometimes receive requests that are outside your focus or beyond capacity. If you ever have overflow, I'd love to be the person you refer to — and of course, I'd do the same for you. Open to a quick call?

Type 2: Agency Partnerships (White-Label Work)

Marketing agencies regularly need web design and development work. They have the client; they need the execution. As a white-label partner, you do the work under their brand — they manage the client relationship and keep a margin. You get a steady stream of paid projects without any client acquisition effort.

Agency Partnership Pitch

'When your clients need web work faster than your team can deliver, I mirror your quality at 70% of what you'd charge the client — you keep the margin. I sign NDAs, deliver on your timelines, and never contact your clients directly.'

Type 3: Complementary Service Referrals

Connect with professionals whose clients also need web design: graphic designers (they design, you build), brand strategists, copywriters, SEO consultants, social media managers, business coaches, accountants. Each relationship is a mutual referral opportunity. One warm introduction from a trusted copywriter is worth 20 cold emails.

Setting Up Your Referral Incentive Program

Cash referral fee: Pay 10% of the project value to anyone who refers a paying client. \$3,000 site = \$300 referral fee.

Service credit: Give referrers a month of free maintenance or a discount on future projects.

Reciprocal referral: Promise to refer your own clients back to them for their services.

Module 5 Complete — Your Client Pipeline Is Live

You have a warm outreach system with a 50-person contact list

You've launched on at least one freelance platform

Cold outreach is sending 5+ emails per week

Content is going out 3x per week on LinkedIn

You have 1–2 partnership conversations started

MODULE 5 MILESTONE — 10 Warm Leads in Tracker

Module 5 Milestone:

Log 10 warm leads in a tracking spreadsheet

Columns: Name, Company, Channel, Date Contacted, Status, Next Action

A 'lead' is anyone who has received an outreach message from you

Update this tracker every week — it IS your business pipeline

PAID MODULE

MODULE 6

Sales: From Lead to Signed Contract

"Sales is just problem-solving with confidence"

MILESTONE

First discovery call completed + proposal sent

Lessons in this module

- 6.1** The Discovery Call Framework
- 6.2** Writing Proposals That Win
- 6.3** Handling Objections Like a Pro
- 6.4** Contracts: Protect Yourself Before Work Starts
- 6.5** Invoicing & Getting Paid on Time

MODULE 6**LESSON 6.1**

The Discovery Call Framework

3 goals · 10 questions to ask · Listen for real pain vs. surface desires

The Discovery Call Is the Most Valuable 20 Minutes in Your Business

The discovery call has one job: determine whether this client is a good fit and gather the information you need to quote accurately and write a winning proposal. It is NOT a sales pitch. It is a structured conversation where you listen more than you talk. The best discovery calls feel like consulting sessions — by the end, the client should feel like you've already started solving their problem.

3 Goals of Every Discovery Call

Goal 1: Understand the client's real problem (not just their stated want)

Goal 2: Assess whether they're a good fit (budget, communication style, timeline)

Goal 3: Gather enough information to write a specific, accurate proposal

The 10 Questions to Ask on Every Discovery Call

Business Understanding

"Tell me about your business — what do you do and who do you serve?"

"What's working well for you right now, and what's the biggest challenge?"

Website Goals

"What is the primary goal of the new website? (Leads, sales, credibility, e-commerce?)"

"Who is your ideal customer, and what should they do when they land on your site?"

"Do you have a website now? What do you like about it? What do you dislike?"

Context & Competition

"Can you share 2–3 websites in your industry that you admire? Why do you like them?"

"Who are your main competitors, and how do you want to be positioned against them?"

Project Scope & Budget

"Do you have a budget in mind for this project? (Most clients will give a range)"

"What's your timeline? Is there a specific date the site needs to be live by?"

"Have you worked with a web designer before? How did that experience go?"

Real Pain vs. Surface Desires

A client says: 'I just want a clean, modern website.' That's the surface desire. The real pain: 'My current site looks unprofessional and I'm losing clients to competitors who have a better online presence.' Your job is to uncover the real pain, because your proposal should solve that — not just build a 'clean site.'

How to dig deeper: After they describe what they want, ask: 'What would change for your business if the website did exactly that?' Or: 'What's been the cost of not having this solved yet?' The answers reveal the real business problem — and let you position your price against the cost of inaction.

After the Call

- Send a follow-up email within 1 hour summarizing what you discussed
- Include your proposed next step: 'I'll send over a detailed proposal within 48 hours'
- Prepare the proposal the same day while the conversation is fresh

ACTION TASK — Discovery Call Preparation

Prepare for your first discovery call:

Print or save these 10 questions — have them in front of you

Book a 20-minute call (Google Meet or Zoom — both free)

Take notes in real time — never rely on memory

Send your follow-up email template within 1 hour

MODULE 6**LESSON 6.2**

Writing Proposals That Win

Full structure · Investment reveal · Proposify/PandaDoc · Template included

A Proposal Is Not a Quote — It's a Sales Document

Most freelance proposals are a list of deliverables and a price. Winning proposals are structured sales documents that demonstrate understanding, build confidence, and make saying yes feel like the obvious choice. A great proposal does three things: shows you understood the client's problem, explains how you'll solve it, and justifies the investment in terms of business value.

The Winning Proposal Structure

Section 1: The Cover:

Your name/logo, their business name, date, and proposal title. Keep it clean.

Section 2: Understanding the Challenge:

2–3 paragraphs showing you listened. Restate their problem in their words. This shows empathy and understanding — more powerful than any feature list.

Section 3: The Proposed Solution:

Describe what you'll build and why each element addresses their specific goals. NOT a generic feature list — a tailored solution tied to their stated challenges.

Section 4: The Process:

Your 6-step workflow (from Module 2.3). Clients buy process as much as output — it shows you're organized and professional.

Section 5: Timeline:

A simple project timeline with milestones. Week 1: Discovery. Week 2–3: Design. Week 4–5: Build. Week 6: Review and Launch.

Section 6: The Investment:

Present your three tiers first (from Module 4.3). Recommend one tier based on what they described. Never bury the price at the end — present it confidently.

Section 7: What Happens Next:

Clear next step: 'To move forward, sign below and submit your deposit.' Remove friction — one action, not five.

Section 8: About Me:

Brief background, key results, 1–2 testimonials. Reinforce credibility at the moment of decision.

Proposal Tools

Tool	Price	Best For
Proposify	\$49/mo	Beautiful templates, e-signature, analytics (see when client opens)
PandaDoc	\$19–\$49/mo	Similar to Proposify, strong e-signature, CRM integrations
Better Proposals	\$19/mo	Excellent templates, affordable, great for beginners
Notion + DocuSign	Free + \$15/mo	Build in Notion, send via DocuSign — DIY but professional
Google Docs + PDF	Free	Simple but lacks e-signature — use HelloSign free tier for signing

Proposal Best Practices

Length: 4–6 pages maximum. Longer is not more professional — it's harder to read.

Send within 48 hours of the discovery call. After 72 hours, enthusiasm drops fast.

Follow up on unopened proposals after 2 days. Proposify/PandaDoc shows you when it's been read.

Never send a proposal without a verbal 'I'll send it over and follow up Thursday' — create the expectation.

ACTION TASK — Proposal Template

Build your proposal template this week:

Create a master template using the 8-section structure

Use Notion, Google Docs, or Better Proposals

Fill in all the static content (your process, about section)

Leave placeholders for the custom sections (challenge, solution, pricing)

Sign up for a free DocuSign or HelloSign account for e-signatures

MODULE 6

LESSON 6.3

Handling Objections Like a Pro

'Think about it' · 'Too expensive' · 'Getting other quotes' — word-for-word responses

Objections Are Not Rejections — They're Requests for More Information

When a client says 'I need to think about it,' they're not saying no. They're saying 'I'm not yet confident enough to say yes.' Your job is to find the specific gap in confidence and close it. Every objection has a predictable underlying concern — learn to identify and address that concern, and your close rate will double.

"I need to think about it."

Underlying concern: Fear of commitment / unspoken concern

Response: "Of course — this is an important decision. Can I ask, is there a specific aspect you'd like to think through? I'm happy to answer any questions now, or I can follow up in a couple of days. What would help you feel most confident?"

Pro Tip

Uncover the real objection. Don't let them leave without naming it.

"That's more than I expected / too expensive."

Underlying concern: Budget mismatch or doesn't see the value

Response: "I completely understand. Can I ask — what were you expecting? [Listen.] The investment we're talking about would [specific result]. When you think about it in those terms, does the math make sense for your business? If the budget is genuinely a constraint, I can put together a scaled-down version that focuses on the essentials."

Pro Tip

Always tie price back to ROI. Offer scope reduction, not discount.

"I'm getting other quotes."

Underlying concern: Comparison shopping / price pressure

Response: "That makes total sense — you should compare options. A few questions to ask any designer: What does the price include after launch? How many revisions are included? Will you own all the code and files? I'm happy to send you a full breakdown of everything included so

you can compare accurately."

Pro Tip

Educate them on what to look for. Position you as the expert.

"I have a nephew who does websites."

Underlying concern: Wants cheap / doesn't see professional difference

Response: "That's great! If he has the time and skills to handle it, that could work well. If you find it's taking longer than expected or the results aren't quite right, I'm always here. I specialize in [your niche] and typically help businesses like yours get [specific result] — happy to chat if you'd like a second opinion at any point."

Pro Tip

Don't argue. Sow a seed. They often come back.

"We don't have the budget right now."

Underlying concern: True budget constraint or not a priority

Response: "I understand — timing matters. Two options: I can put together a phased plan where we start with the essentials this month and add features over time, OR I can hold your spot in my schedule for [next month] if that timing works better. Which would be more helpful?"

Pro Tip

Offer flexibility. A delayed yes beats a no.

ACTION TASK — Objection Practice

Practice objection handling this week:

Read all 5 objection scripts out loud — twice each

Role-play with a friend: they give the objection, you respond naturally

Record yourself and listen back — does it sound confident? Natural?

The goal: respond without hesitation, calmly and with genuine empathy

MODULE 6

LESSON 6.4

Contracts: Protect Yourself Before Work Starts

8 essential clauses · Scope · IP · Kill fee · Revisions · Late payment

A Contract Is Not Optional — It's Your First Line of Defense

No contract has ever cost a freelancer a legitimate client. But the absence of a contract has cost thousands of freelancers months of unpaid work, endless revisions, and nightmare disputes. Every project — even for friends and family — requires a signed contract before you start. No exceptions.

The 8 Contract Clauses You Cannot Skip

1. Scope of Work

A detailed description of exactly what you will deliver. List every page, every feature, every deliverable. Then add: Any work not specified above is considered out of scope and will be quoted separately.

Why it matters: This is your protection against unlimited scope creep.

2. Payment Terms

The amounts, schedule, and consequences for late payment. Standard: 50% deposit before work begins, 50% before launch. Invoices unpaid after 14 days incur a 2% monthly late fee. Never start work without the deposit.

Why it matters: Protects you from clients who disappear mid-project or delay final payment.

3. Revision Limits

How many rounds of revisions are included. Typically 2–3 rounds. Define a revision round as one batch of consolidated feedback, not continuous back-and-forth. Additional revisions beyond those included will be charged hourly.

Why it matters: Without this clause, revision requests can continue forever with no additional pay.

4. Intellectual Property

Who owns the finished site. Standard: client owns the finished work after final payment is received. You retain the right to display it in your portfolio. This should be explicit in writing.

Why it matters: Ambiguity around IP is one of the most common freelance disputes — eliminate it upfront.

5. Kill Fee

What happens if the client cancels mid-project. Standard: client pays for all work completed plus 25-50% of the remaining balance. This compensates you for blocked calendar time and work-in-progress.

Why it matters: Without this clause, a client can cancel and you have no recourse for lost income.

6. Launch Timeline / Client Responsibilities

Client agrees to provide all content (text, images, logo) by an agreed date. Project timeline assumes timely feedback within 5 business days of each delivery. Delays caused by late client feedback will extend the timeline accordingly.

Why it matters: Prevents clients from blaming you for delays caused by their own slow feedback.

7. Dispute Resolution

Both parties agree to attempt resolution through good-faith negotiation before pursuing legal action. This agreement is governed by the laws of your state or country.

Why it matters: Sets clear expectations about how conflicts are handled without going straight to court.

8. Confidentiality (NDA)

Freelancer agrees to keep all client business information confidential and not to disclose it to third parties without written consent. Simple but critical.

Why it matters: Essential for clients in regulated industries like healthcare or finance.

Where to Get a Professional Contract Template

Bonsai (hellobonsai.com): \$24/mo — includes contracts, proposals, and invoicing

AND.CO (free): Basic contract templates

AIGA Design Contract: Free, industry-standard template

Your own lawyer: Best for high-value contracts (\$10K+)

This course includes a ready-to-use 8-clause contract template — customize with your details.

ACTION TASK — Contract Setup

Contract setup this week:

Download the included contract template (in your course resources)

Fill in your name, business name, and default rates

Set up a free DocuSign or HelloSign account for electronic signatures

Practice rule: zero work begins before a signed contract AND deposit received

MODULE 6

LESSON 6.5

Invoicing & Getting Paid on Time

50/50 payment structure · FreshBooks · Wave · Bonsai · International payments

Getting Paid Should Never Be an Afterthought

Cash flow is the life blood of a freelance business. Late payments are one of the top causes of freelance stress and business failure. The solution is a bulletproof invoicing system set up from day one — before you have clients. When your process is professional, clients pay on time because they know exactly what to expect.

The 50/50 Payment Structure

Never start work without a deposit. The standard in web design is 50% upfront, 50% before launch. The upfront deposit ensures you're compensated if the client disappears. The final payment before launch ensures you're paid before handing over access credentials. Some freelancers use 3-part structures for larger projects:

Structure	When Paid	Best For
50/50	50% start, 50% before launch	Standard projects under \$5,000
33/33/33	33% start, 33% midpoint, 33% launch	Larger projects \$5K–\$15K
25/25/25/25	25% at 4 milestones	Long projects over \$15K
100% upfront	Full payment before start	Small projects under \$500, or new clients you don't trust

Invoicing Tools

Wave (waveapps.com) — Free

Professional invoices, online payment processing (2.9%+\$0.30 per transaction), expense tracking. Best free option.

FreshBooks — \$17–\$55/mo

Time tracking, expense management, client portal, excellent reporting. Best paid option.

Bonsai (hellobonsai.com) — \$24/mo

Combines contracts, proposals, invoicing, and project management. Best all-in-one for freelancers.

PayPal — Free (2.9% fee)

Simple, universally accepted. Not ideal for professional invoicing but fine for early clients.

Wise Business — Low fees

Best for international clients — multi-currency, low conversion fees, fast transfers.

What to Do When a Client Doesn't Pay

Day 1 overdue: Polite reminder email: 'Hi [Name], just checking in on invoice #[X] due [date]. Please let me know if you have any questions.'

Day 7 overdue: Follow-up with urgency: 'Invoice #[X] is now 7 days overdue. Please process payment today or let me know if there's an issue we can resolve.'

Day 14 overdue: Formal notice: cite late fee clause from contract. Pause any ongoing work until payment received.

Day 30 overdue: Final notice before escalation: collections agency, small claims court, or simply go public if necessary.

Module 6 Complete — You Can Now Close Deals

Discovery call framework with 10 key questions

Proposal structure that positions you as a strategic partner

Word-for-word objection responses for every common scenario

Contract with all 8 protective clauses in place

Professional invoicing setup with 50/50 payment structure

MODULE 6 MILESTONE — First Discovery Call + Proposal Sent

Module 6 Milestone:

- [] Schedule your first discovery call
- [] Send your first proposal within 48 hours
- [] Set up Wave or Bonsai for invoicing
- [] Never start a project without a signed contract AND deposit

PAID MODULE

MODULE 7

Client Management & Project Delivery

"Happy clients become your best marketing"

MILESTONE

End-to-end project delivery system fully documented

Lessons in this module

- 7.1 The Client Onboarding System
- 7.2 Communication Protocols That Prevent 95% of Problems
- 7.3 Managing Revisions Without Losing Your Mind
- 7.4 Project Delivery & Launch
- 7.5 Retaining Clients for Monthly Revenue

MODULE 7**LESSON 7.1**

The Client Onboarding System

Welcome email within 24h · Questionnaire · Notion workspace · Kickoff call

The First 72 Hours Set the Tone for the Entire Project

The moment a client signs and pays the deposit, the clock starts on their experience of working with you. A disorganized, slow start signals that the rest of the project will be the same. A smooth, professional onboarding sequence immediately builds confidence and sets the expectation that they made the right choice. Every great client experience starts with great onboarding.

Day 0 — Deposit Received

Send the welcome email within 2 hours (template below). This is your first impression after signing. Thank them, confirm what happens next, and give the timeline. Never leave a new client wondering 'what now?'

Day 1 — Onboarding Questionnaire

Send a detailed questionnaire to collect all the information you need before touching any design tool. Include: business name, tagline, target audience, key services/products, brand assets (logo, colors, fonts if they exist), content preferences, competitor sites they like/dislike, any must-have features, login credentials if updating an existing site.

Day 2 — Project Workspace

Create a shared project space — a Notion page or ClickUp project — and share it with the client. Include the project timeline, deliverables list, your communication norms, and a place to upload assets. This single action makes you look more professional than 90% of freelancers.

Day 3 — Kickoff Call

30–45 minute call to review the questionnaire answers, clarify anything unclear, confirm the project scope, and align on priorities. Use this to also set expectations: revision process, feedback turnaround time, communication channel preference.

Week 1 — First Design Direction

Present a mood board or first design concept. Never disappear for 2 weeks after the kickoff call — clients get anxious. Even a quick 'Here's what I'm working on' message keeps the relationship warm.

Welcome Email Template (Send Within 2 Hours of Deposit)

Subject: Welcome to [Your Name] Studio — Here's What's Next

Hi [Client First Name],

I'm thrilled to be working with you on [Project Name]! I've received your deposit and we're all set to go.

Here's what happens next:

- Today: I'll send over a short onboarding questionnaire — it takes about 15 minutes and helps me create exactly what you're looking for.
- By [Date+2 days]: I'll set up your project workspace and share a link.
- [Date+3 days]: Let's schedule our kickoff call — I've included a booking link below.

Expected launch date: [Agreed date]

Your project manager: Me — and I respond to messages within 24 hours on business days.

Looking forward to creating something great for [their business]!

[Your Name]

ACTION TASK — Onboarding System Setup

Build your onboarding system this week:

Write your welcome email template and save it in Gmail/Outlook as a canned response

Create a Notion template for client project workspaces

Write a 15-question onboarding questionnaire in Google Forms or Notion

Set up a Calendly (free) link for kickoff call booking

MODULE 7

LESSON 7.2

Communication Protocols That Prevent 95% of Problems

Response time norms · Scope creep handling · Weekly status update templates

Most Project Problems Are Communication Problems in Disguise

The most common cause of scope creep, unhappy clients, and delayed projects is not technical problems — it's unclear expectations. When the client doesn't know what to expect, they assume. When they assume and you deliver something different, conflict follows. Set every expectation in writing, and 95% of project conflicts will never happen.

Setting Communication Norms (Do This on the Kickoff Call)

Response time: I respond to messages within 24 hours on business days, Monday–Friday. For urgent matters, [phone/WhatsApp].

Communication channel: All project communication goes through [email / Notion comments / Slack]. Please avoid mixing channels.

Feedback turnaround: I'll need feedback on each design deliverable within 5 business days. Delays here can affect our launch date.

Meeting schedule: We'll have a weekly 15-minute check-in on [day] at [time] unless there's nothing to review.

Out of office: If I'm unavailable for more than 24 hours, I'll notify you in advance.

The Weekly Status Update Template

Send a brief status update every Friday, even on active projects. This keeps clients informed, builds trust, and eliminates the 'what's happening?' emails that interrupt your flow.

Friday Status Update Template

Subject: [Project Name] — Weekly Update

Hi [Name],

Quick update on where we are this week:

Completed: [What was done this week]

In progress: [What's being worked on]

Next up: [What's coming next week]

Action needed from you: [Anything they need to review or provide]

On track for our [launch date] target. Let me know if you have any questions!

[Your Name]

Handling Scope Creep: Scripts That Work

Scope creep is when clients request work outside the original agreed scope. The key: catch it early and address it in a way that maintains the relationship while protecting your time.

Scope Creep Response Script

Client: 'Can you also add a blog section, a booking system, and an e-commerce page?'

Your response: 'Great ideas! Those aren't included in our current scope, but I can put together a quick quote for those additions. Would you like me to include them in Phase 2 after the current launch, or would you prefer to scope them into this project now with an adjusted timeline and investment?'

Key: always offer a path forward, never just say no.

ACTION TASK — Communication System

Create your communication system document:

Write your communication norms as a 1-page PDF

Send it to every new client with the welcome email

Set up a weekly calendar reminder to send Friday status updates

Create a saved email template for scope creep responses

MODULE 7**LESSON 7.3**

Managing Revisions Without Losing Your Mind

Revision limits · Structured feedback forms · Saying no professionally

Unmanaged Revisions Are the #1 Profit Killer in Web Design

A \$2,000 project with 3 rounds of structured revisions is profitable. A \$2,000 project with unlimited back-and-forth changes over 6 weeks is a loss. The solution is not to be rigid or difficult — it's to structure the revision process from day one so both parties know exactly what's included and what isn't.

Defining 'A Revision Round'

A revision round is one consolidated batch of feedback, not an ongoing conversation. After each design delivery, the client has 5 days to collect all their feedback and send it in one message. You implement those changes. That's one round. Not: client sends feedback, you change it, they see it and request more changes, and so on indefinitely.

Set Revision Expectations in the Kickoff Call

'Your package includes 2 rounds of revisions. A revision round means you gather all your feedback into one message, I implement the changes, and you review again. After 2 rounds, any additional changes are billed at \$[rate]/hour. This keeps us on schedule and ensures the project stays within budget for both of us.'

The Structured Feedback Form

Unstructured feedback kills projects. 'I don't like it' is not actionable. Send a feedback form with every design delivery to get specific, organized input.

- Overall impression: Does this feel right for your brand? (1–10)
- What specifically do you like about this design?
- What specifically doesn't feel right? (Be as detailed as possible)
- Colors: Do the colors feel correct for your brand and audience?
- Typography: Is the text readable and does the font feel right?
- Layout: Is all the key information visible and in the right order?

- Call to action: Is the main action button clear and compelling?
- Any other specific changes you'd like to see in the next version?

Saying No to Out-of-Scope Requests Professionally

The word 'no' by itself damages the relationship. The phrase 'Yes, and here's what that looks like' maintains it. Always offer a path forward — even if that path costs more.

The 'Yes And' Script for Out-of-Scope Requests

Client: 'Can you just quickly add [feature not in scope]?''

Your response: 'I'd love to add that! It's not included in our current scope, so I'll put together a quick quote — for something like this it would typically be around \$[amount] and take about [X days]. Should I add it to the project, or would you like to handle it after launch?'

Never apologize for quoting additional work. You're running a business.

ACTION TASK — Revision System Setup

Create your revision management tools:

Build a Google Form with the 8 feedback questions above

Add revision policy language to your contract template

Save the 'Yes And' script as a canned email response

Set a rule: never implement changes without written feedback

MODULE 7**LESSON 7.4**

Project Delivery & Launch

25-point pre-launch checklist · Site handoff guide · Testimonial request timing

Launch Day Is a Professional Moment — Make It Feel Like One

The launch of a client's website should feel like an event, not just pressing a publish button. A professional launch process builds excitement, ensures nothing is broken, gets the final payment collected, and sets up the relationship for ongoing work. Follow this process on every project.

The 25-Point Pre-Launch Checklist

Content & Copy

- All placeholder text replaced with real content
- All images have descriptive alt text (accessibility + SEO)
- No typos — proofreading pass done by a fresh set of eyes
- Contact information is correct and consistent throughout
- Privacy Policy and Terms of Service pages are live

Design & UX

- Site tested on iOS and Android mobile devices
- Tested on Chrome, Firefox, Safari, and Edge browsers
- All buttons and links work correctly
- Contact forms submit and send emails correctly
- Images are compressed and under 200KB each
- No broken images or missing assets

Performance

- PageSpeed Insights score: 70+ mobile, 85+ desktop
- Site loads in under 3 seconds on mobile
- Images served in WebP format where possible
- Caching plugin active (WordPress) or site hosted on CDN

SEO & Analytics

- Page titles written for every page (include keywords)
- Meta descriptions written for every page
- Google Analytics or Plausible connected
- Google Search Console verified and sitemap submitted
- Favicon (browser tab icon) is set

Security & Backup

- SSL certificate active (https:// not http://)
- Automatic backup system configured
- Admin passwords are strong and shared securely
- Login page protected (WordPress: WP Login Lockdown or similar)
- WordPress plugins and theme are up to date at launch

The Site Handoff Guide

Every project ends with a handoff document — a 1–2 page guide that tells the client everything they need to know to use their new site. Include:

- Login credentials for the CMS (delivered via a password manager or secure email)
- How to update: text, images, and blog posts (include 2-minute Loom video walkthrough)
- Who to contact for technical issues (your email, with response time commitment)
- Renewal dates: hosting, domain name, SSL certificate
- Emergency contacts: their hosting provider support line

Requesting Testimonials (Timing Is Everything)

The best time to request a testimonial is 24–48 hours after launch, when the client's excitement is highest and they can see their site live. Never ask for a testimonial before delivery is complete.

Testimonial Request Email

Subject: Quick favor — and your new site is live!

Hi [Name],

Your new site is officially live — congratulations! It was a genuine pleasure working on this with you.

I have a small favor to ask: if you're happy with how the project went, a short written testimonial would mean the world to me. Even 2–3 sentences about your experience works perfectly.

You can reply here or leave a review on [Google Business / Clutch.co].

Thank you so much, and I look forward to seeing your business grow!

[Your Name]

ACTION TASK — Launch System Setup

Launch process setup:

Save the 25-point checklist as a PDF — use it on every project

Create your site handoff guide template

Draft your testimonial request email and save as canned response

Run a practice audit on your own portfolio site using the checklist

MODULE 7

LESSON 7.5

Retaining Clients for Monthly Revenue

Care plans \$200–\$2K/mo · SEO upsells · Maintenance pitch · Recurring income

Recurring Revenue Is the Key to a Stable Freelance Business

A single project client pays once. A retainer client pays every month for years. The difference between a freelancer in constant feast-or-famine mode and one with a predictable, stable income is often just 3–5 retainer clients. Once your site is launched, pitching ongoing maintenance is the single most impactful business development action you can take.

The Website Care Plan (Your Easiest Upsell)

After launch, every WordPress site needs: security updates, plugin updates, backups, uptime monitoring, and occasional content edits. Most business owners don't want to deal with this — and they'll pay handsomely not to. This is your monthly care plan.

Care Plan Tier	What's Included	Monthly Price
Basic	Plugin updates, backups, uptime monitoring, security scan	\$100 – \$200/mo
Standard	Basic + 1hr content edits, monthly performance report, priority support	\$250 – \$500/mo
Premium	Standard + 3hrs edits, SEO reporting, quarterly strategy call	\$600 – \$1,500/mo

Care Plan Pitch (Use This at Launch)

'Now that the site is live, let me tell you how I keep it healthy. Every WordPress site needs regular security updates and backups — if these don't happen, sites get hacked, which can cost \$500–\$2,000 to fix. My care plan handles all of this for \$150/month. I also include 1 hour of content updates per month — so when your hours change or you add a new service, just email me and it's done. Want to add that?'

Additional Retainer Services to Upsell

SEO Retainer — \$500–\$2,000/mo

Monthly keyword tracking, blog content, link building, Google Analytics reporting. Position as: 'Your site is live — now let's make sure Google sends you traffic.'

Social Media Management — \$400–\$1,500/mo

Manage Instagram, Facebook, LinkedIn. Many clients who hire you for a site also need content help. Easy cross-sell, especially with AI tools.

Monthly Performance Report — \$200–\$400/mo

Analytics report with actionable insights: traffic, conversions, what's working. Low effort (use Google Looker Studio), high perceived value.

Ad Management (Google/Meta) — \$500–\$2,000/mo

Set up and manage paid ads. Requires more skill, but extremely high-value retainer. Learn the basics of Google Ads with a \$100 budget.

Module 7 Complete — You Have a World-Class Delivery System

Professional onboarding sequence with welcome email and kickoff call

Communication protocols that prevent 95% of project conflicts

Structured revision system with feedback forms

25-point pre-launch checklist

Care plan offerings to convert one-time clients into recurring revenue

MODULE 7 MILESTONE — Recurring Revenue System

Module 7 Milestone:

Write your care plan offer and price it for your market

Add the care plan pitch to your post-launch email sequence

Track monthly retainer income separately — this is your 'stability number'

Goal: 3 care plan clients = \$600+/mo stable base income by month 6

PAID MODULE

MODULE 8

Scaling: From Freelancer to Business

"Build systems so the business runs without you"

MILESTONE

Full business system documented in a single Notion workspace

Lessons in this module

- 8.1 Business Foundations & Legal Setup
- 8.2 Building Systems That Scale
- 8.3 Building Your Personal Brand
- 8.4 Hiring, Outsourcing & Building a Team
- 8.5 Income Diversification & Passive Revenue

MODULE 8**LESSON 8.1**

Business Foundations & Legal Setup

LLC vs. sole trader · Business banking · Taxes · When to hire an accountant

Get the Business Foundation Right Before You Scale

Most freelancers operate as sole proprietors indefinitely — which works fine at low income levels, but creates unnecessary personal liability and tax complications as revenue grows. At some point (typically \$3,000+/month in recurring revenue), it makes sense to formalize the business structure. This lesson covers the essentials — always consult a local accountant or attorney for jurisdiction-specific advice.

Business Structure Options

Sole Trader / Sole Proprietor

The simplest structure — you and the business are one legal entity. No registration required in most jurisdictions. Taxes are simple: report income on your personal return. Downside: no personal liability protection. Best for: early-stage, under \$3,000/month.

LLC (Limited Liability Company — US)

Separates personal and business assets. If a client sues, they can only pursue business assets, not your personal bank account. Pass-through taxation (profits taxed at personal rate). Cost: \$50–\$500 to register depending on state. Best for: anyone earning \$3,000+/month or working with larger clients.

Limited Company (UK / Australia / others)

Similar to LLC — separate legal entity, liability protection. More administrative overhead (annual filings, separate tax returns). Best for: higher earners who want tax efficiency and professional credibility.

Business Banking

Open a dedicated business bank account from day one. This is non-negotiable for tax purposes and professionalism. It also makes it infinitely easier to track income and expenses. Options: traditional business banking (Chase, Bank of America), or neobanks like Relay, Mercury, or Wise Business (excellent for international freelancers). Mercury is free and widely loved by freelancers.

Tax Essentials for Freelancers

- Set aside 25–30% of every payment immediately into a separate savings account for taxes

- Track every business expense — software subscriptions, equipment, home office, internet
- In the US: pay quarterly estimated taxes (April, June, September, January)
- Business expenses reduce your taxable income — tools, courses, and equipment are deductible
- Hire a bookkeeper once you hit \$5,000/month — the \$150/month saves you far more in taxes
- Use QuickBooks Self-Employed or Wave for simple expense tracking from day one

When to Hire an Accountant

Many freelancers try to manage taxes themselves to save money — and end up overpaying, missing deductions, or filing incorrectly. Hire an accountant when: (1) you earn more than \$5,000/month, (2) you form an LLC or company, (3) you have multiple income streams, or (4) you hire contractors. A good accountant saves you 3–5x their fee in taxes and time.

ACTION TASK — Business Foundation

Business foundation tasks:

- ☐ Open a dedicated business bank account
- ☐ Set up Wave (free) or QuickBooks for expense tracking
- ☐ Start a tax savings account — automatically save 27% of every payment
- ☐ Research your local LLC formation requirements
- ☐ Get a business email: yourname@yourdomain.com (Google Workspace \$6/mo)

MODULE 8

LESSON 8.2

Building Systems That Scale

Repeatable 6-step workflow · Template library · Zapier automation · Tool stacks

Systems Are What Turn a Freelancer Into a Business

A business with systems can grow, delegate, and run without the owner doing every task manually. A freelancer without systems is the bottleneck of their own business — nothing moves unless they personally do it. The goal of this lesson: document and systematize every repeatable task in your workflow so you can eventually delegate, automate, or sell the business.

What to Systematize First

System	Priority	What to Document
Client onboarding	HIGH	Your welcome email, questionnaire, Notion template, kickoff call agenda — all templated so they take 15 minutes instead of 2 hours
Proposal creation	HIGH	A master proposal template where you only change the specific sections — project name, challenge, solution, and price
Project delivery	HIGH	The 25-point launch checklist, the handoff guide template, the testimonial request email — all ready to go
Invoicing	HIGH	Template invoices in Wave/Bonsai with your payment terms pre-filled — takes 2 minutes per invoice
Weekly marketing	MEDIUM	Content calendar, outreach tracker, follow-up sequences — batch and schedule weekly
Project management	MEDIUM	A Notion or ClickUp template for every new client project — duplicated and shared instantly

Building Your Template Library

Every time you create a design element, a code snippet, or a workflow document from scratch, you're reinventing a wheel. Build a template library so that everything you create once can be reused forever.

- Website section templates (hero, services, testimonials, about, footer) in Figma and your builder
- Color palette collection: 5–10 professional palettes for different industry types
- Typography pairings: 5 tested font combinations that always work
- Cold email templates for each niche you target
- Proposal template, contract template, invoice template
- Feedback form, onboarding questionnaire, kickoff call agenda
- Content calendar and LinkedIn post templates

Automation With Zapier and Make (formerly Integromat)

Examples of automations that save 2–4 hours per week:

New Calendly booking automatically creates a Notion project page and sends welcome email

New invoice paid in Wave sends a thank-you email and creates a project archive

New contact form submission adds to CRM (HubSpot free) and sends auto-reply

New LinkedIn post drafted schedules via Buffer or Publer

Project milestone completed automatically sends client status update

ACTION TASK — Systems Documentation

Systems building this month:

Document your current workflow step-by-step in Notion

Identify 3 tasks you do manually that could be automated or templated

Build a template for each

Create a Zap for your most repetitive admin task

Goal: by month 6, your core systems run with 50% less manual effort

MODULE 8

LESSON 8.3

Building Your Personal Brand

LinkedIn optimization · 3-posts/week strategy · Email list · Lead magnets

Your Personal Brand Is Your Most Durable Competitive Advantage

Tools change. Platforms evolve. But a personal brand that positions you as the go-to expert in your niche is virtually impossible to copy. When your brand is strong, clients come to you. Rates become non-negotiable. The 'I'll think about it' objections disappear. Building a personal brand is a 6–18 month investment with compound returns that grow forever.

The 3 Elements of a Strong Freelance Personal Brand

Clear positioning: You are known for one specific thing for one specific type of client. Not 'web designer' — 'the WordPress designer for fitness coaches.'

Consistent content: You show up regularly on 1–2 platforms. Every post reflects your expertise, personality, and point of view. Consistency over volume.

Proof of results: Your brand is backed by real client outcomes. Case studies, testimonials, and quantified results make your brand credible, not just visible.

LinkedIn Brand-Building System (3 Posts Per Week)

LinkedIn is the highest ROI social platform for B2B freelancers in 2025. Business owners, marketing managers, and decision-makers are active here. Three posts per week, consistently, for 6 months will build meaningful inbound.

Monday — Teach: Share a tip, tutorial, or lesson from your work. Pure value, no self-promotion. Format: Hook line 3–5 bullet points CTA to comment.

Wednesday — Show: Behind-the-scenes, work-in-progress, or before/after. Visual posts perform 2x better than text-only. Even a screenshot with context works.

Friday — Prove: Client result, testimonial, or case study summary. End every week by building credibility. '3 weeks ago I built [X]. Here's what happened.'

Email List: Your Most Valuable Long-Term Asset

Social media platforms are rented land. Your email list is property you own. Start building it from month one — even 50 engaged subscribers can generate consistent project inquiries. The formula: create a free lead magnet that solves a real problem for your target client. Give it

away in exchange for their email.

Lead magnet ideas that work:

- 5 Website Mistakes That Are Losing You Clients (and How to Fix Them)
- The Website Launch Checklist: 25 Things to Check Before Going Live
- The 2025 Small Business Website Blueprint (for your specific niche)
- Free Website Audit: I'll review your current site and send 5 specific improvements

Use MailerLite (free up to 500 subscribers) to collect emails and send monthly newsletters. One newsletter per month is enough — share a tip, a case study, and your availability for new projects.

ACTION TASK — Brand Building Launch

Personal brand actions this week:

Write your LinkedIn headline with your niche and specialty

Write your first 3 LinkedIn posts and schedule them

Create a 1-page lead magnet (PDF checklist) on Canva

Set up a MailerLite account and add a signup form to your portfolio

MODULE 8**LESSON 8.4**

Hiring, Outsourcing & Building a Team

Subcontractors · Micro-agency model · VAs — delegate the right tasks first

You Cannot Scale Beyond Your Own Hours Without People

A solo freelancer has one hard ceiling: 24 hours per day. To earn beyond that ceiling, you need to bring other people into the work — subcontractors, virtual assistants, or specialist partners. This doesn't mean building a 10-person agency overnight. It means strategically adding one person at a time, starting with the tasks that take your time but could be done by someone else.

What to Delegate First

Order of delegation: highest-time + lowest-skill tasks first.

Delegate	Role	Rate	Tasks
Admin & Communication	VA (Virtual Assistant)	\$8–\$20/hr	Inbox management, scheduling, invoice follow-up, data entry, social media scheduling
Content writing	Copywriter	\$30–\$80/hr	Website copy, blog posts, LinkedIn content, case studies
Graphic design	Graphic designer	\$25–\$60/hr	Logos, brand assets, social media graphics, presentation decks
Development tasks	Developer	\$40–\$100/hr	Backend integration, complex JS, API work, WooCommerce customization
SEO	SEO specialist	\$30–\$80/hr	Keyword research, on-page optimization, link building, reporting

The Micro-Agency Model

At \$8K–\$15K/month, many freelancers transition to a micro-agency model: a small team of 2–4 contractors working under your brand. You own the client relationships and strategy; contractors handle execution. Your margin on each project increases as your own billable hours decrease. This is the path from freelancer to business owner.

Micro-Agency Example: How the Numbers Work

Project value: \$5,000

Your time: 10 hours (client management, strategy, QA) × \$200/hr imputed = \$2,000

Contractor: 30 hours of execution × \$60/hr = \$1,800

Gross margin: \$5,000 - \$1,800 = \$3,200 profit for your 10 hours

Effective rate: \$320/hr — 2–3x your solo rate

Where to Find Contractors

- Upwork: large pool, vetted reviews, managed payments
- Contra: 0% commission, high-quality creative professionals
- LinkedIn: search specific roles and reach out directly
- Your own network: past clients, designer communities, Twitter/X
- Design communities: Slack groups, Facebook groups, Discord servers

ACTION TASK — First Delegation

Delegation planning:

List every task you do in a typical week

Highlight tasks that don't require YOUR specific skills

Identify 1 task to outsource in the next 30 days

Start with a small test project (\$100–\$300) before committing long-term

Create a brief document explaining how you work — your 'contractor onboarding'

MODULE 8

LESSON 8.5

Income Diversification & Passive Revenue

Courses · Templates · Affiliate revenue · Agency arbitrage · 12-month income map

Building Multiple Income Streams From Your Expertise

Once your active client income is stable and your systems are documented, you can start building income streams that generate money without direct time investment. This is the shift from trading time for money to building assets that pay you repeatedly. It takes time to set up — but the compounding effect over 2–3 years is dramatic.

The Income Diversification Ladder

Stream	Setup Effort	Monthly Income Potential	When to Start
Client projects (active)	Ongoing	\$3K–\$20K+/project	Month 1
Monthly care plans	Low (pitch at launch)	\$200–\$2K/mo per client	Month 2
Subcontracting margin	Medium (find partners)	20–40% on referred work	Month 4
Digital templates	One-time (10–20 hrs)	\$500–\$5K/mo passive	Month 6–9
Online course / workshop	Medium-high (50–100 hrs)	\$1K–\$10K+/launch	Month 9–12
Affiliate commissions	Very low (write reviews)	\$100–\$1K/mo passive	Month 3+
Agency white-label	Low (build relationships)	\$2K–\$8K/mo	Month 5+

Digital Templates: The Fastest Passive Income

If you've built website templates for yourself or clients, you can sell them. Platforms: Envato Market (ThemeForest), Creative Market, Gumroad, your own website. A quality WordPress or

Webflow template can sell for \$29–\$299 and generate \$500–\$3,000/month once established with the right marketing.

Creating and Selling a Course

Everything you've learned in this business — the niche strategy, the cold outreach, the pricing psychology — is valuable knowledge someone will pay to learn. A beginner course on 'How to Get Your First Web Design Client' or 'WordPress for Small Business Owners' can generate \$1,000–\$10,000 per launch. Platform options: Gumroad (simple, low fee), Teachable, or Podia.

Affiliate Revenue

You already recommend tools to clients: hosting providers, builders, stock photo services, email marketing tools. Most have affiliate programs paying 20–50% recurring commission. Sign up for: Webflow Affiliate, SiteGround, Elementor, Hostinger, ConvertKit, Bonsai. Write honest reviews on your blog or portfolio site and earn passively from your existing recommendations.

Your 12-Month Income Map

Timeline	Revenue Target	Income Composition
Month 1–3	\$0–\$4,000	1–2 active projects + care plans starting
Month 4–6	\$3,000–\$7,000	Consistent pipeline, 2–3 retainers, affiliate revenue starting
Month 7–9	\$5,000–\$10,000	Templates listed, agency partnership, 4–6 care plans
Month 10–12	\$8,000–\$18,000+	Course launch, subcontracting, strong referral engine

Module 8 Complete — You're Building a Business

Business structure and banking set up professionally

Core systems documented and template library growing

Personal brand publishing 3x per week on LinkedIn

First delegation identified — moving toward micro-agency model

Income diversification plan with a 12-month roadmap

MODULE 8 MILESTONE — Business OS Complete

MODULE 8 MILESTONE — Full Business System in Notion:

Create a Notion workspace with 5 sections:

1. Client Pipeline (all active leads and projects)
 2. Template Library (all reusable assets)
 3. Systems Hub (all documented processes)
 4. Financial Tracker (income, expenses, tax savings)
 5. Content Calendar (LinkedIn posts, email newsletters)
- This single workspace IS your business operating system.

You now have everything: the mindset, the tools, the strategy, the client acquisition channels, the sales strategy, and the scaling roadmap. The only thing standing between you and your next client is execution.

Your Quick-Reference Cheat Sheet

Topic	Key Number / Rule
Starter hourly rate	Calculate: (Monthly goal × 1.3 + expenses) ÷ 67 hours
Basic site price	\$800 – \$1,500 (beginner), \$1,500 – \$4,000 (established)
E-commerce price	\$5,000 – \$20,000+ depending on complexity
Care plan price	\$100 – \$500/month (Basic to Standard tier)
Proposal deadline	Send within 48 hours of discovery call
Contract deposit	50% before any work begins — no exceptions
Revision rounds	2–3 rounds per project (defined in contract)
Portfolio projects needed	3 outstanding case studies (quality > quantity)
Content frequency	3 posts per week on LinkedIn — consistency is everything
Tax savings rate	Set aside 25–30% of every payment
Rate increase cadence	Every 6–12 months — set a calendar reminder now
Follow-up timing	Days 1, 4, 8, 14 — 80% of replies come after first follow-up
Testimonial request	24–48 hours after launch — enthusiasm is highest

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